CANON LAW SOCIETY OF NIGERIA (CLSN)

In Justitia Pax

38th ANNUAL CONVENTION

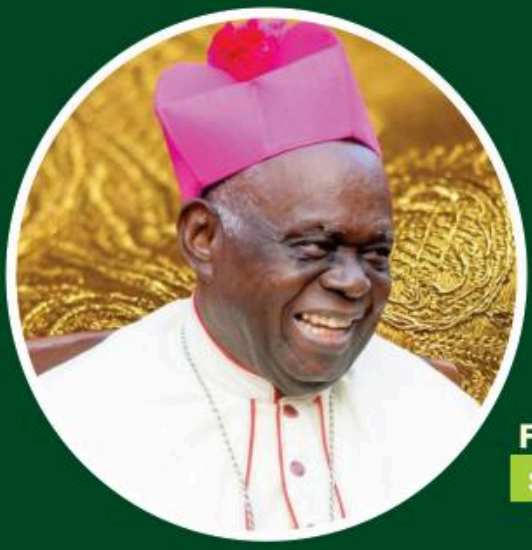
THEME

CANON LAW AND CLERICAL POLITICAL ENGAGEMENT IN NIGERIA: ENSURING ECCLESIAL UNITY, MISSION AND CREDIBILITY

&

95th BIRTHDAY ANNIVERSARY

of



His Lordship, Most Rev.

ANTHONY OKONKWO GBUJI

EMERITUS BISHOP OF ENUGU DIOCESE & FOUNDER OF CANON LAW SOCIETY OF NIGERIA

SPECIAL BOOK LAUNCH & FESTSCHRIFT PRESENTATION

HOLY GHOST CATHEDRAL OGUI, ENUGU | ST. JOSEPH PARISH EMENE

TUESDAY 27TH — FRIDAY 30TH OCTOBER 2026

Heartfelt Felicitations

Your Excellency,
Most Rev. Anthony Okonkwo GBUJI,
Bishop Emeritus Enugu,

On the joyful occasion of your 95th birthday and 53rd anniversary of Episcopal Ordination, I offer my heartfelt congratulations and thanksgiving to God for the gift of your life and ministry.
It was a profound privilege to work under your leadership and pastoral guidance. Your wisdom, faith, and dedication have left a lasting mark on my life and priestly ministry.

May God continue to bless you with peace, strength, good health, and abundant grace, as you celebrate this remarkable milestone.
May your years ahead be filled with the joy of knowing how many lives you have touched and inspired.
Happy 95th Birthday and 53rd Episcopal Anniversary, Your Excellency!

Ad multos annos!

Very Rev. Fr. Dr. Major Hilary Ike
Judicial Vicar II,
Catholic Diocese of Columbus,
Command Chaplain,
643D RSG BDE, United States Army





Office of the Apostolic Administrator
CATHOLIC ARCHDIOCESE OF BENIN CITY

October 10, 2026

Very Rev. Fr. Dr. Edwin Omorogbe
President,
Canon Law Society of Nigeria.

Dear Fr. Edwin Omorogbe

CONGRATULATIONS ON YOUR DOUBLE CELEBRATION

On behalf of the Apostolic Administrator, Most Rev. Dr. Donatus Ogun, OSA, the Priests, Religious, and lay faithful of the Archdiocese of Benin City, it is with great joy and profound gratitude to God that I extend our warmest good will greetings ta the Canon Law Society of Nigeria on the occasion of its 38th Annual Convention and the celebration of the 95th birthday of its revered Founder, a former Apostolic Administrator of the Archdiocese of Benin City, Most Rev. Dr. Anthony Gbuji.

The Annual Convention is a significant opportunity to reflect on the enduring importance of Canon Law in the life and mission of the Church, deepen our understanding of its Principles, and renew our commitment to justice, discipline, good governance, and pastoral within the ecclesiastical community.

As we celebrate this milestone, we honour the vision, dedication, and pioneering contribution of Bishop Anthony Gbuji, whose initiative and commitment laid the foundation for the growth and development of the Society. Attaining the remarkable age of 95 is a profound blessing and a testament to a life of service, faith, and dedication to the Church. We thank God for his life and pray that the Almighty will continue to sustain him with good health, peace, joy, and the grace of His abiding presence.

May this 38th Annual Convention provide renewed inspiration, fruitful deliberation, and fresh insights that will strengthen the practice and appreciation of Canon Law in Nigeria and beyond. May the Society continue to flourish in its mission of promoting canonical scholarship, fidelity to the laws of the Church, and the advancement of justice in the service of God's people.

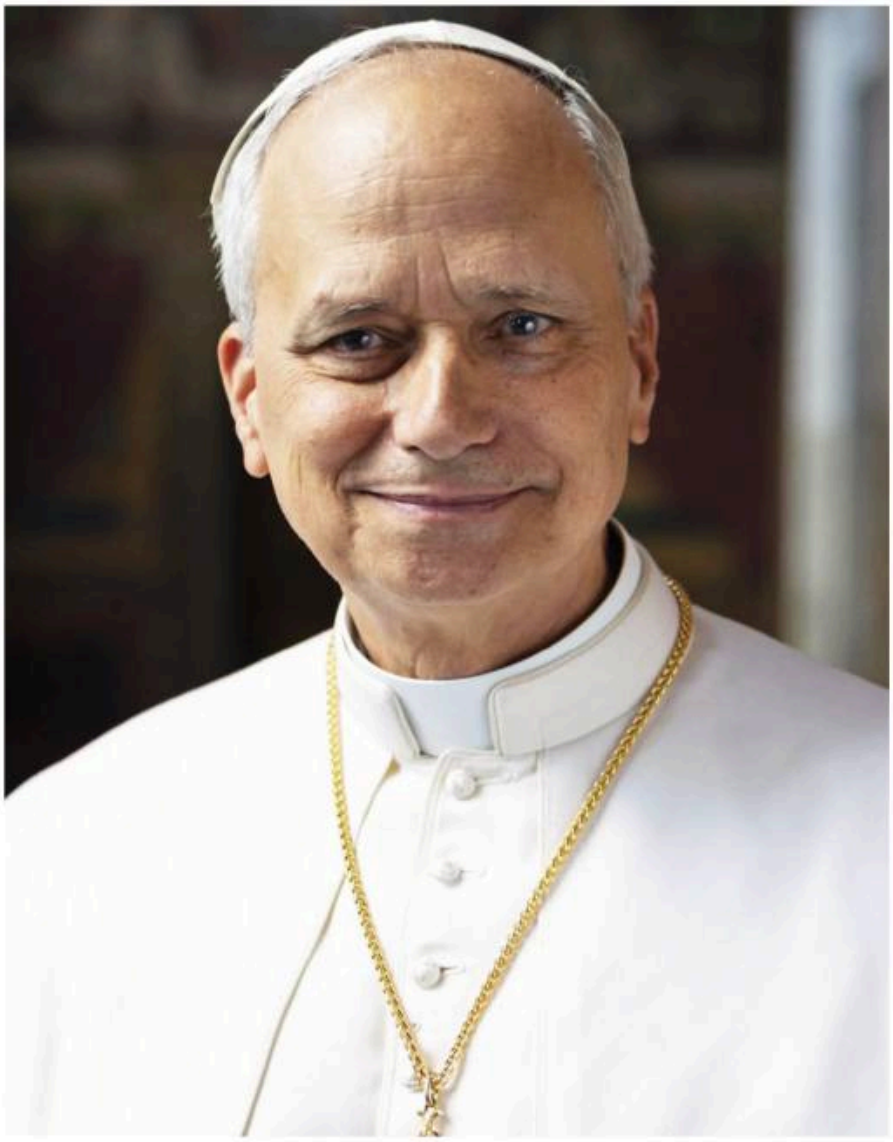
Please accept our heartfelt congratulations and best wishes for a successful and memorable convention, as well as our sincere prayers and felicitations to Bishop Anthony Gbuji on his 95th birthday. May God bless the Canon Law Society of Nigeria, reward the noble- efforts of its Founder, and grant the Society many more years of fruitful service to the Church and humanity.

Congratulations and best wishes.

Sincerely your in Christ

Very Rev. Fr. Dr. Michael Oyanoafoh
Chancellor, Archdiocese of Benin City

Chancery Ofiice:
30, Airport Road, P.o. Box 35, Benin City, Edo State-Nigeria



HIS HOLINESS

POPE LEO XIV



HIS LORDSHIP, MOST REV.

CALLISTUS CHUKWUMA ONAGA

Bishop of Enugu Diocese

THEME: CANON LAW AND CLERICAL POLITICAL ENGAGEMENT IN NIGERIA: ENSURING ECCLESIAL UNITY, MISSION AND CREDIBILITY



HIS LORDSHIP, MOST REV.

ERNEST ANEZICHUKWU OBODO

Auxiliary Bishop of Enugu Diocese &
Apostolic Administrator of Abakaliki Diocese
Chairman, Canon Law Commission of the
Catholic Bishops Conference of Nigeria, CBCN

THEME: CANON LAW AND CLERICAL POLITICAL ENGAGEMENT IN NIGERIA: ENSURING ECCLESIAL UNITY, MISSION AND CREDIBILITY



HIS EMINENCE, PETER CARDINAL

EBERE OKPALEKE

Bishop of Ekwulobia Diocese

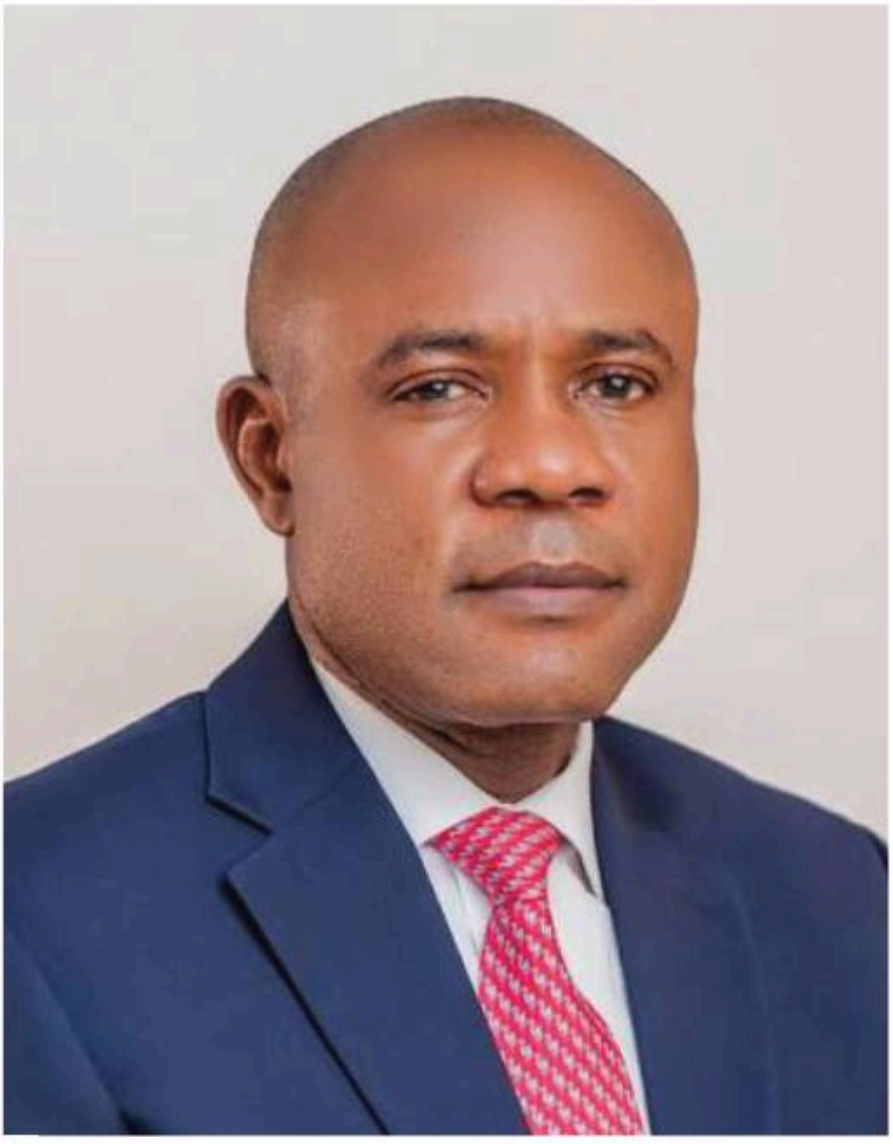


HIS LORDSHIP, MOST REV.

ANTHONY OKONKWO GBUJI

Emeritus Bishop of Enugu Diocese &
Founder, Canon Law Society of Nigeria

THEME: CANON LAW AND CLERICAL POLITICAL ENGAGEMENT IN NIGERIA: ENSURING ECCLESIAL UNITY, MISSION AND CREDIBILITY



DR. PETER NDUBUISI MBAH

Executive Governor of Enugu State

THEME: CANON LAW AND CLERICAL POLITICAL ENGAGEMENT IN NIGERIA: ENSURING ECCLESIAL UNITY, MISSION AND CREDIBILITY



VERY REV. FR.

EDWIN OMOROGBE, J.C.D.

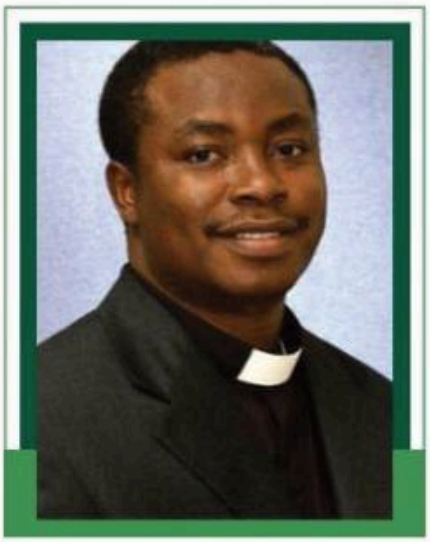
National President, Canon Law Society of Nigeria

THEME: CANON LAW AND CLERICAL POLITICAL ENGAGEMENT IN NIGERIA: ENSURING ECCLESIAL UNITY, MISSION AND CREDIBILITY

NATIONAL EXECUTIVE MEMBERS



Rev. Fr. Hilary Odili Ben Ezenwa, JCD,
National Vice-President



Very Rev. Fr. Edwin Omorogbe, J.C.D.
National President, Canon Law Society Of Nigeria



Rev. Fr. Dr. Charles E. Essien
National Secretary



Rev. Fr. Stephen Timothy Akpan
National Director Research and Publication



Rev. Fr. Daniel Gyang, JCL
National Asst. Secretary



Rev. Sr. M. Cheluchi Emenike, DDL
National Treasurer



Rev. Sr. Mary Ijechukwu Ihembu, DMMM
National Financial Secretary

A CONCISE HISTORY

OF THE CANON LAW SOCIETY OF NIGERIA

The history of the Canon Law Society of Nigeria is like the proverbial and providential mustard seed, which, although very tiny in size, later grew into a large tree where birds from all over come to find shelter. Furthermore, the small gathering of about 16 Canon lawyers has grown into an internationally recognised society. The history of the Canon Law Society of Nigeria cannot be told separately from that of its parent organisation: The Catholic Bishops' Conference of Nigeria (CBCN) Commission on Canon and Civil Laws, with its first Chairman, His Excellency, Most Rev. Anthony Okonkwo Gbuji. Therefore, the origins of the Canon Law Society of Nigeria trace back to 1982, when Bishop Anthony Gbuji was appointed by the Catholic Bishops of Nigeria to establish the legal department of the Catholic Secretariat of Nigeria. He then formed a commission comprising experts in Canon Law and Civil Laws from the three Ecclesiastical Provinces of Nigeria at that time.

The period following the end of the Vatican Council II Sessions and the Post-Conciliar movements and theological and ecclesiological currents was a period of unprecedented activities of interpretation, adaptation, revision, updating and assimilation of the conciliar ecclesiology of Vatican Council II, as well as the revision of the 1917 Code of Canon Law. Consequently, some of these pioneer Nigerian canonists were products of that inter-codal renaissance. With the promulgation of the new code in March 1983, the birth of the Canon Law Society of Nigeria on 13th March 1985 became a necessity to fill that ecclesiastical void of understanding the letters and spirit of the new Code in the spirit and animation of the theological principles of the Second Vatican Council. Thus, Bishop Anthony Gbuji, in his capacity as a foremost Nigerian Canon Lawyer and the first elected Chairman of the Catholic Bishops' Conference of Nigeria (CBCN) commission on Canon and civil laws, mandated the then secretary of the commission, the late Rev. Fr. Column Daley, OP, to invite members of the commission for the crucial and historic inauguration of the Canon Law Society of Nigeria. There is no doubt that they drew their inspiration from such sister societies like the Canon Law Society of America, Canon Law Society of Great Britain and Ireland, Canon Law Society of Canada etc.

The foundation members were:

Most Rev. Dr. Anthony Okonkwo Gbuji (the Initiator)
Most Rev. Dr. Emmanuel Otteh
Rt. Rev. Msgr. Cyriacus Mbah
Rt. Rev. Joseph Omesa
Rev. Fr. Martin Igwe Uzoukwu (now Bishop Martin Uzoukwu)
Rev. Fr. Hilary Odili Okeke (now Bishop Hilary Okeke)
Rev. Fr. Column Daley OP
Rev. Fr. Benedict Etafo
Rev. Fr. Eugene Onuoha
Rev. Fr. Bernard Ngwoke
Rev. Fr. Philip Chinyelu
Rev. Fr. Matthew Iwuji
Rev. Msgr. Longinus Etoh
Rev. Fr. Fabian Essien
Rev. Fr. Emmanuel Asuquo Akpan

The inauguration took place on 13th March 1985 at the Diocesan Pastoral Centre, Issele-Uku in Delta State. About six of these Founding Fathers have been called by the Lord, while some are no longer very active in the Canon Law Society, either due to old age, retirement or other disabilities. However, some are still very active and supportive, especially the prelate father founder, Bishop Anthony Gbuji, a President Emeritus, Bishop Hilary Paul Odili Okeke and the former Chairman of the Silver Jubilee Committee, Msgr. Joseph Omesa (now late).

The late Msgr. Cyriacus S.N Mba, a seasoned and experienced Canon Lawyer, was elected the first President of the society, while Bishop Anthony Gbuji, the then Bishop of Issele-Uku, the founder and the moving spirit of the Society, has continued to be the Grand Patron of the society. Another prominent figure among the pioneer members and Father Founders is Most Rev. Hilary Odili Okeke, the Bishop Emeritus of Nnewi, and one-time Secretary and later President of the Society and still a committed member and sponsor of the society.

Most Rev. Dr. Martin Igwe Uzoukwu served the society in various capacities. He served the society as its General Secretary. He has continued to identify with the aims and objectives of the society. Rev. Sr. Prof. Gerald Nwagwu of DMMM served as a two-term secretary. She later became the President of the Society from 1997 to 2002. She has remained a veritable contact linking the past and the present. She became the first professor of Canon Law in Nigeria. Rev. Fr. Prof. John U. Gangwari was elected President in 2002 and served the society for six years. His tenure witnessed several publications of Canon Law Series, which helped to bring the

History of the Canon Law Society of Nigeria

Society to lime light. In 2009, Rev. Fr. Dr Jonas Benson Okoye (now Bishop of Nnewi Diocese) was elected President of the Society. Immediately he came into office, he was faced with the challenge of organizing the Silver Jubilee of the Society which was celebrated at Our Lady Queen of Nigeria Pro - Cathedral, Area 3, Garki Abuja on the 10th of November, 2010, Ever since then, he has led the society to greater heights; has created website for the society; incorporated the Society with Corporate Affairs Commission. He worked assiduously with his Executive members to initiate the building of a National Secretariat for the Society.

A very significant date in the history of the Canon Law Society of Nigeria is 19th November 1986, with the adoption of its constitution, which was ratified and approved by the Catholic Bishops' Conference of Nigeria (CBCN) in 1991. Unlike its civil counterparts and other professional bodies in Nigeria, the society is *sui generis,* and so the aims and objectives of the society are not just to protect the welfare of its members but to be at the service of the wider ecclesial community. Hence, its membership is open to professionals and non-professionals alike and indeed to all Christ's faithful in Nigeria and from all over the world. However, there are two types of membership: Professional membership, open to those who have at least a licentiate (or its equivalent) in Canon Law and Associate Membership: open to all those who do not have the academic degree for Professional membership but wish to associate themselves with the aims and activities of the society.

Within two years of its formation, the Canon Law Society of Nigeria had become not only a voice in ecclesiastical governance and administration but also a vital tool in the hands of the Nigerian Catholic hierarchy to ensure the smooth and orderly governance of our particular Churches. It also fulfilled the Episcopal Conference's responsibilities, such as formulating complementary norms, drawing up statutes, and establishing the constitution of both public and private juridical persons within the Church. Furthermore, it supported the Church's ministry of justice and the development of instruments for mediation, arbitration, conciliation, and conflict resolution. The Society achieved this through organised annual conventions focused on current issues, which have been disseminated via publication of the Annual Canon Law Proceedings and Newsletters. Since 1987, it has consistently held annual conventions across Nigeria's various ecclesiastical regions. The Newsletter serves as the Society's periodical, documenting not only its activities but also current issues in the Catholic Church in Nigeria, recent events related to the Apostolic Society, including the annual Allocutio of the Pope to the Supreme Tribunal of the Roman Rota— the highest appellate tribunal of the Church. It also features written judgments from Ecclesiastical tribunals in Nigeria, aiming to develop a Nigerian jurisprudence suited to our context.

Beyond these conventions and the Newsletter, the Society has, since 1994, regularly organised annual seminars exclusively for professional members, usually held between February and March, thanks to the sponsorship of Most Rev. Dr. Hilary Odili Okeke, one of the leading figures in Canon Law in Nigeria. In 2017, however, the professional seminar moved to Port Harcourt, sponsored by Most Rev. Dr. Camilus Etokudoh (Bishop Emeritus of Port Harcourt Diocese), in recognition of Bishop Okeke's longstanding generosity. In addition, the Society has published numerous works by individual members and fellow Canonists, including other notable publications such as*: Lay People in the Church and in the World* (Onitsha Canon Law Series no. 1. 1992) and *Marriage and the Family in Nigeria* (Onitsha: Rex Charles Patrick, 1994). The Annual General Meeting of the Society has always been held in November each year, initially at Issele-Uku at the instance and expense of the Father Founder, Bishop Anthony Gbuji, but with the transfer of His Lordship to Enugu in 1997, it has been held at Enugu, also at his expense till his retirement.

The Annual Convention of the Society now lasts for about four days and includes: Launching of previous Conference Proceedings and the current year's Newsletter, commissioned and voluntary papers, as well as General Meeting and elections if applicable. On November 19th, 2015, at the 29th Convention in Port-Harcourt, Rev. Msgr. Dr. Pius Kii was elected the new National President with a new set of Executives to pilot the affairs of the Society for the next few years. The transfer of the baton of leadership of this Society has witnessed progress. For the first time last year, 2016, the Canon Law Society of Nigeria had a guest lecturer all the way from the United States of America. This was a great opportunity because it added great value to the convention and society, as the presence of Dr Edward Peters at the convention in Warri in November 2016 did not just play the role of a resource person but also officially registered himself as a member of the Canon Law Society of Nigeria. With his registration, he became the second American citizen to be a member of our society after Maryjo Gretsinger. The expansion of the society's membership beyond the shores of Nigeria obviously manifests

History of the Canon Law Society of Nigeria

the worth of the society within and outside the shores of Nigeria. Most importantly, it is to internationalise the society and give it a professional character that a society of this sort should be through intellectual crossbreeding. Continuing from the effort of the past Executive body of this society, greater effort has been intensified through effective communication to reach out to Canonists in Nigeria and at the 2017 Port Harcourt Convention; Canonists from the West African region are expected at this Convention. The effort to reach out to Canonists through effective communication has significantly improved the membership strength of the Society, attendance at Conventions and Professional Seminars, which, since the year 2016, have been serialised.

Within the shortest time of the inception of this new Executive body, the Canon Law Society of Nigeria has intensified its contribution to the Church in Nigeria through the Catholic Bishops by always presenting to them the intellectual fruits of the society's Annual Convention and Professional Seminars. After the 2016 Annual Convention, the society presented to the Catholic Bishops' Conference of Nigeria a document on the Canonical perspective of healing ministry in the Church in Nigeria and a document on the briefer process for Marriage nullity that would be uniformly applied in the Ecclesiastical tribunals in Nigeria. The society intends to continue through its new Executive body to continue to provide similar interventions for the benefit of the local Church.

After the successful tenure of Msgr. Pius Kii – led executive, the administrative organ of the Society, changed at the 2022 Convention and AGM at Uyo, Akwa Ibom State (Nov. 14 - 18). Very Rev. Frs. Edwin Omorogbe, JCD and Hilary Odili Ben Ezenwa, JCD, were overwhelmingly elected to the offices of President and Vice-President, respectively. With Fr. Dr Charles Essien as Secretary and other capable officers of the new executive, expectations were high that the Society would get to a higher pedestal. And true to the projections, the new EXCO team immediately hit the ground running. The 35th Annual Convention hosted by Onitsha Archdiocese at Madonna Renewal Centre, Nkpor, from Nov. 14 to Nov. 17, 2023, was quite fruitful. Attendance was at a superlative degree. The event saw, among other highlights, the Society's founding father, Most Rev. Anthony O. Gbuji, conferred with a unique prestigious award through the hands of the one and only Cardinal member of our Society and CBCN Chairman on Canon Law, Peter Ebere Cardinal Okpaleke. Before the echoes from that Onitsha convention had died down, the executive rose from a couple of Zoom meetings and drew progressive roadmaps. In 2024, the Society held its annual convention in Benin City and was magnanimously hosted by the Archdiocese of Benin. This conference, with its uniqueness and finesse, attracted notable personalities and professionals, from the 23rd – 27th of September, 2024, at the Bishop Kelly Pastoral Centre, Benin City.
In just about two years of taking charge, the Society witnessed further transformation and notable innovations.

1. There was the collection and creation of a database for canonists in all the provinces of Nigeria with their areas of specialization.

2. Appointment of coordinators for the nine provinces who mostly are Judicial Vicars of the Metropolitan See.

3. Planning and organization of the annual professional seminars at the provincial levels to encourage better participation of members due to less travel inconveniences and security risks.

4. Updating of the Society's registration with the Corporate Affairs Commission (CAC).

5. Development of a functional website for the Society.

6. The Canon Law Society of Nigeria National Secretariat: This is unarguably the giant of all these notable new developments in the Society. It is a big milestone as the idea of having such a secretariat remained a mirage until the last two years, 2023, when Chief Gabriel Osarinwe Igbinedion (Esama of Benin Kingdom) not only donated choice land for this in Okada but promised to sponsor it. Today, true to his promise, the huge structure is fast springing up. The keys of a completed Secretariat would have, in fact, been handed over during last year's Conference in everlasting memorial of his 90th birthday, but for some unforeseen hitches. It was the main reason for moving up the Convention/AGM to September 2024, instead of the usual November month and the choice of Benin City as the hosting place. Perhaps this is the first time in history that the CLSN convention was anticipated earlier. Indeed, the God of hosts is with this Society, and the God of Jacob is its stronghold.

With the pace of work on the site, this current executive is confident that it would not be long before all our eyes would see a completed National Secretariat officially bequeathed to us by the Esama of Benin, then blessed and opened for the use it was originally conceived, constantly intended and finally realized.



Biography Of MOST REV. DR. ANTHONY OKONKWO GBUJI ON HIS 95th Birthday

Most Rev. Anthony Okonkwo Gbuji, was born at the Church's doorstep at St. Charles Catholic Church, Ubulu-Uku on the 29th of October, 1931 to Alexander Gbuji, a devoted catechist of Idumu Okode, Umuekeke Quarter in Akwukwu-Igbo, Oshimili North L.G.A Delta State. While his mother Agnes Gbuji, hails from Ubulu-Uku. He is the fifth child in a family of twelve children.

He was deeply influenced by the exemplary Christian lives of his parents, and zeal of the early missionaries such as Frs. Abraham Ojefua, Paul Emechete and J.C. Lyons SMA. As a mission boy, he showed great interest in the priestly life, and was admitted into St. Theresa's Minor Seminary Oke-Are, Ibadan 1947, and then to St. Paul's Major Seminary, Benin-City 1952 where he studied philosophy. He was later sent to Pontifical Urban University Rome for his Theological studies. Upon completing his theological studies, he was ordained a priest in Rome on the 23rd of November, 1958, by Pietro Cardinal Agagianian, of the Armenian Eastern Catholic Church, then Prefect of the Congregation for the Evangelization of Peoples. Among his fellow eighty-eight ordinands was Francis Cardinal Arinze. After his ordination, he continued his studies, bagging Licentiate in Theology (1959) and Summa Cum Laude (First Class Honours) in his Doctorate in Canon Law (1962).

On concluding his studies in Rome in 1962, he went on to London University, Institute of Education for the Diploma Certificate in Education. Afterwards, he returned home to Benin Diocese where he immediately engaged in the formation of the youth at the secondary school level and this is one aspect of his life that deserves greater recognition. His first place of pastoral assignment was to establish St. John's Grammer School Fugar (1963-1966), formator at St. Paul's Minor Seminary, Benin City (1966-1967), later he became the Principal at St. Paul's Grammer School Ebu, Delta State (1967-1968) and Principal of St. Thomas' Teachers Training College Ibusa, Delta State (1968-1973).

On 5th July, 1973, Pope Paul VI, appointed him the first Bishop of Issele-Uku Diocese and he was consecrated by Most Rev. Anthony Olubunmi Okogie, the then Archbishop of Lagos and other co-consecrating Bishops. He began his episcopal ministry in the new created diocese with eight parishes and eight priests. During his episcopacy in Issele-Uku Diocese, he established the following: Canon Law Society of Nigeria (1982), St. Felix Minor Seminary Ejeme-Aniogor (1983), Mother of Perpetual Help Girls Juniorate, (1984), Emmaus School of Evangelization, (1989), New Evangelization Sisters of Our Lady of Perpetual Help (1993). Among the various contributions he made is the deepening of faith in our people. His work on "Traditional Title Taking" helped the Church in Nigeria to resolve the issue that barred the Catholic elites from membership of the House of Lords where the laws of the country were enacted .

After 24 years as Bishop of Issele-Uku, the Holy See on the 8th of November, 1996 appointed him Bishop of Enugu Diocese. He was installed on 8th February, 1997. His episcopacy in Enugu was very impactful. He established the the "Unum Presbyterium – the family of priests" and the "Curial form of governance" that strengthened the unity of love between the Bishop and his priests. Following the principle of grassroot evangelization, about 75 parishes were created. To bring the Church closer to the people, the Diocese of Agwu was carved out of the densely Catholic populated Enugu Diocese in 2005. To promote unity at the intellectual level, he conceived the idea of "Cor Unum University", that emerged in 2009 as Godfrey Okoye University, which within the period of 17 years of establishment, ranks the 41st in excellence out of the 328 Universities in Nigeria. In response to Pastores Dabo Vobis of St. Pope John Paul II, proposing the best system for formation of priests for the Third Millenium, St. Bernard Seminary Hostel, Nchatancha Nike Enugu was established. After Twelve years as Bishop of Enugu, the Holy See accepted the resignation of His Excellency Most Rev. Anthony Okonkwo Gbuji and appointed Most Rev. Callistus Onaga to succeed him in 2009.

After his retirement, he was appointed the Apostolic Administrator of Archdiocese of Benin City (2010-2011). He came back to Enugu to his retirement home where he devotes himself to promoting the New Evangelization Research And Ministry (NERAM). Here Lay People are taught Theology, Missionary Spirituality, skills for teaching the Catechism of the Catholic Church and skills in Collaborative Pastoral Ministry. Lay People are thus prepared to assist the clergy in the pastoral areas where they cannot function alone e.g. Rite of Christian Initiation of Adults (R.C.I.A), preparing couple through counselling for a successful and happy marriage and the establishment and care of Small Christian Communities (SCC).

On October, 29th 2026, he celebrats his 95th birthday, 68th year as a priest and 53rd year as a Bishop. We are ever grateful to God for His blessings and graces to the Bishop emeritus. We continue to pray for more fruitful years in good health of mind and body.
There are three basic things that stand out in the life of Most Rev. A. O. Gbuji. First is that he has been a builder of Institutions. Second, is that he is known to combine scholarship with practical pastoral work and thirdly, is that he works at a meeting point of Faith and Culture. He has researched extensively and published many books.

I wish to thank our Bishop Most Rev. Callistus Chukwuma Onaga the Catholic Bishop of Enugu Diocese who has continued to care and support our Emeritus Bishop all these years. We ask the good Lord to bless him abundantly. To our Auxilliary Bishop and the Apostolic Administrator of the Catholic Diocese of Abakaliki, Most Rev. Ernest Aniezichkwu Obodo, we remain ever grateful for his sacrifices and support to our Emeritus Bishop. May the good Lord reward him abundantly. To all who in one way or the other work for the success of the birthday and this National Convention, may the same good Lord reward them all most abundantly.

REV. FR. NESTOR NGWUIFE
Personal Secretary/Chaplain to the Emeritus Bishop
(17-10-2026)

CANON LAW SOCIETY OF NIGERIA ANNUAL CONVENTION ENUGU

TUESDAY 27TH OCTOBER 2026 - FRIDAY 30TH OCTOBER 2026

PROGRAMME

Tuesday 27 October, 2026

3.00p.m. **Arrival and Registration**
Welcome to Domus Sancti Spiritus Guest House, Holy Ghost Cathedral, Enugu.
Finance Officers (Sr Ijeoma Ihembu, DMMM, Sr. Maria Nkoli Cheluchi Emenike, DLL) to be on standby for Registration of Attendees

6.00p.m. Pre-Convention Meeting - President & Exco Meet

7.00p.m. Vespers / Dinner

8.00p.m. PAPER PRESENTATIONS (Tuesday Night)

Preliminaries: Time Regulation
i. Duration of Presentation: 25 Minutes
ii. Moderator's Intervention: 5 Minutes
iii. General Interventions: 20 Minutes

8.00p.m. A1 - Fr. Dr. Charles Ndubisi, *"Theological and Pastoral Foundations for Clerical Political Neutrality: An Examination of Canons 285 and 287".*
Moderator: Fr. Dr. Justine Nwafor | Time Keeper: Fr. Gold Lawrence

A2 - Fr. Dr. Raphael Ejimonye, *"Canonical Norms Governing Clerical Conduct in Political and Civic Life".*
Moderator: Fr. Dr. Clement Agu | Time Keeper: Sr. Florence Ogbudu

WEDNESDAY 28 OCTOBER, 2026

7.00 a.m. Morning Prayer - Deacons/Religious Sisters

7.30 a.m. Breakfast

9.00 a.m. Holy Mass - SS Simon & Jude, Apostles, Feast, Liturgical Colour: **Red**
Principal Celebrant - Most Rev. C.V.C. Onaga (Bishop of Enugu), Homilist: Most Rev. Anthony O. Gbuji

11.00 a.m. Opening Ceremonies (Jubilee Hall)
Preliminaries: Introduction of the MC
- Opening Prayer and Welcome by Most Rev. C.V.C. Onaga

- Presentation of Kolanuts - Fr. Dr. Alfred Nwoye, Judicial Vicar, Enugu Diocese
- An Address by the Chairman of Canon Law Committee, Catholic Bishops' Conference of Nigeria: Most Rev. Ernest Obodo, Apostolic Administrator of Abakaliki Diocese and Auxiliary Bishop of Enugu
- Convention Presidential Address: President Canon Law Society of Nigeria (Fr. Edwin Omorogbe)
- Paper Presentation - Barr. Ikechukwu Onuoma, SAN, "The Role of the Church in Governance"

-Book Launch/Presentation of Festschrift in honor of Most Rev. Anthony O. Gbuji
- Awards & Support:
- Presentation of Awards: The President, CLSN or his chosen representative - presents the award.
1. Role of Law Award (Bishop Anthony O. Gbuji)
2. Award of Excellence (Governor Barr. Peter Ndubuisi Mba)
3. Award of Fellowship - To distinguished Canonists
4. Merit Award
5. Response by Msgr. Obiora Ike

-Official Presentation of the Canon Law Proceedings (To be anchored by the Director, Research and Publications, CLSN, with other supporting Members)
-Vote of Thanks to be given by the Vice President of CLSN (Rev. Fr. Hilary Ben-Ezenwa)
-Lunch Break
4.00 p.m. PAPER PRESENTATIONS (Wednesday Afternoon)

4.00 p.m. B1 - Fr. Dr. Emmanuel Faweh Kazah, "Balancing Civic Engagement and Ecclesiastical Integrity: Guidelines for Clergy under canons 285 and 287".
Moderator: Fr. Dr. Chimobi Clement Emefu | Time Keeper: Fr. Clement Ability
5.00 p.m. B3 - Fr. Dr. Jude Onyeakazi, "Church Authority and Judgment: Allowing Clergy Involvement under canons 287, §2"
Moderator: Fr. Dr. Patrick Okuta | Time Keeper: Sr. Okoye-Eze Marycordelia

6.00 p.m. B4 - Fr. Dr. Bulus Makama, "Safeguarding Church Unity and Justice: Canonical Remedies for Violation of Canons 285 and 287".
Moderator: Fr. Dr. Justin J. Temswang | Time Keeper: Fr. James Egeonu
7.00 p.m. Vespers | Supper
8.30 p.m. Annual General Meeting of CLSN
i. Minutes and Approval of Agenda
ii. Approval of New Constitution for CLSN
iii. CLSN Convention 2027

THURSDAY 29 OCTOBER, 2026

7.00 a.m. Lauds
7.30 a.m. Breakfast
8.00 a.m. Departure to St Joseph's Church Emene, Enugu
10.00 a.m. 95th Birthday Thanksgiving Mass for Bishop Anthony A. O. Gbuji - Presided over by Bishop A. O. Gbuji, and Homilist Bishop Ernest Obodo, Apostolic Administrator of Abakaliki Diocese.
Venue: St. Joseph Catholic Church, Emene
Color of Vestment: WHITE

Reception : Presentation of Books by Most Rev. Anthony O. Gbuji
11.30 a.m. Reception | Entertainment at the Celebrant's Residence, Emene
3.00 p.m. Excursion to Godfrey Okoye University, Enugu
7.00 p.m. Vespers
7.30 pm Gala Night | Banquet Dinner

FRIDAY 30 OCTOBER, 2026

6.30 a.m. Office of the Dead for Archbishop Augustine Akubeze and other deceased members of the Society | **Holy Mass - Most Rev. Martin Igwemezie Uzoukwu, Homilist - Fr. Edwin Omorogbe**
Vestment: WHITE
7.30 a.m. Breakfast & Departure

SAFE TRIP TO YOUR VARIOUS DESTINATIONS



EUCHARISTIC Celebration

FEAST DAY OF SS. SIMON & JUDE, APOSTLES (RED)

28 October, 2026

ENTRANCE ANTIPHON

These are the holy men whom the Lord chose in his own perfect love; To them he gave eternal glory.

COLLECT

O God, who by the blessed Apostles have brought us to acknowledge your name, graciously grant, through the intercession of Saints Simon and Jude, that the Church may constantly grow by increase of the peoples who believe in you, **Through our Lord Jesus Christ, your Son, Who lives and reigns ...**

FIRST READING(Eph.2:19-22)

A reading from the letter of St. Paul to the Ephesians

You are part of a building that has the apostles for its foundations.

You are no longer aliens or foreign visitors: you are citizens like all the saints, and part of God's household. You are part of a building that has the apostles and prophets for its foundations, and Christ Jesus himself for its main cornerstone. As every structure is aligned on him, all grow into one holy temple in the Lord; and you too, in him, are being built into a house where God lives, in the spirit.

The word of the Lord
Thanks be to God

RESPONSORIAL PSALM(P s. 19:2-3, 4-5 (R.v.5a)

Response: Their word goes forth through all the earth.

1. The heavens proclaim the glory of God and the firmament shows forth the work of his hands, day unto day takes up the story and night unto night makes known the message. (R)

2. No speech, no word, no voice is heard yet their span goes forth through all the earth, their words to the utmost bounds of the world. (R)

GOSPEL ACCLAMATION (Lk.6:12-16)

Alleluia, alleluia! We praise you, O God, we acknowledge you to be the Lord. The glorious company of the apostles praise you, O Lord. **Alleluia!**

GOSPEL(Lk.6:12-16)

A reading from the holy Gospel according to Luke

Jesus picked out twelve of his disciples and called them 'apostles'.

Jesus went out into the hills to pray; and he spent the whole night in prayer to God. When day came he summoned his disciples and picked out twelve of them; he called them 'apostles': Simon whom he called Peter, and his brother Andrew; James, John, Philip, Bartholomew, Matthew, Thomas, James son of Alphaeus, Simon called the Zealot, Judas son of James, and Judas Iscariot who became a traitor.

The Gospel of the Lord
Praise to you Lord Jesus Christ

PRAYER OVER THE OFFERINGS

As we venerate the perpetual glory of the holy Apostles Simon and Jude, O Lord, we ask that you receive our prayers and lead us to worthy celebration of the sacred mysteries .
Through Christ our Lord.

COMMUNION ANTIPHON(Jn.14:23)

Whoever loves me will keep my words, says the Lord; and my father will love him, and we will come to him, and make our home with him.

PRAYER AFTER COMMUNION

Having received this Sacrament, O Lord,
We humbly implore you in the Holy Spirit, that what we do to honour the glorious passion of the Apostles Simon and Jude, may keep us ever in your love.
Through Christ our Lord.



Thanksgiving Mass of the 95th Birthday of
MOST. REV. ANTHONY O. GBUJI
29 OCTOBER 2026

ENTRANCE ANTIPHON (Eph 5:19-20)

Sing and make music to the Lord in your hearts, always thanking God the Father for all thing in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ.

COLLECT

O God, the Father of every gifts, we confess that all we have and are comes from you; teach us to recognize the effects of your boundless care and to love you with sincere heart and with all our strength. Through our Lord Jesus Christ, your Son, who lives and reigns with you in the unity of the Holy Spirit, God, forever and ever. Amen.

FIRST READING (Sirach 50:22-24)

A reading from the book of Sirach

And now, bless the God of all, who has done wondrous things on earth; who fosters people's growth from their mother's womb and fashions them according to his will! May he grant you joy of heart and may peace abide among you; may his goodness towards you endure in Israel to deliver us in our days.

The word of the Lord

RESPONSORIAL PSALM (Ps. 138:1-2ab, 2cde-3, 4-5)

Response: **Lord, I thank you for your faithfulness and love.**

1. I will give thanks to you, O Lord, with all my heart for you have heard the words of my mouth; in the presence of the angels I will sing your praise; I will worship you at your holy temple and give thanks to your name. (R)

2. Because of your kindness and your truth; for you have made great above all things your name and your promise. When I called, you answered me; you built up strength within me. (R)

3. All the kings of the earth shall give thanks to you, O Lord, when they hear the words of your mouth; and they shall sing of the ways of the Lord: "Great is the name of the Lord." (R)

SECOND READING (Phil 4:4-9)

A reading from the letter of St. Paul to the Philippians

I want you to be happy, always happy in the Lord; I repeat, what I want is your happiness. Let your tolerance be evident to everyone: The Lord is very near. There is no need to worry; but if there is anything you need, pray for it, asking God for it with prayer and thanksgiving, and that peace of God, which is so much greater than we can understand.

Finally, brothers, feel your minds with everything that is true, everything that is noble, everything that is good and pure, everything that we love and honour, and everything that can be thought virtuous or worthy of praise. Keep doing all the things that you learnt from me and have been taught by me and have heard or seen that I do. Then the God of peace will be with you.

The word of the Lord.

GOSPEL (1 Thes 5:18)

Alleluia, Alleluia!

In all circumstances, give thanks, for this is the will of God for you in Christ Jesus.

Alleluia!

GOSPEL (Luke 17:11-19)

A reading from the holy Gospel according to Luke

As Jesus continued his journey to Jerusalem, he traveled through Samaria and Galilee. As he was entering a village, ten lepers met him. They stood at a distance from him and raised their voices, saying, "Jesus, Master! Have pity on us!" And when he saw them, he said, "Go show yourselves to the priests." As they were going they were cleansed. And one of them, realizing he had been healed, returned, glorifying God in a loud voice; and he fell at the feet of Jesus and thanked him. He was a Samaritan. Jesus said in reply, "Ten were cleansed, were they not? Where are the other nine? Has none but this foreigner returned to give thanks to God?" Then he said to him, "Stand up and go; your faith has saved you."

The Gospel of the Lord

PRAYER OVER OFFERING

For the gifts you have bestowed, O Lord, we offer you the sacrifice of praise, humbly begging that what you have conferred upon us in our unworthiness we may give back, to the glory of your name. Through Christ our Lord. Amen. **(Preface: Common IV)**

COMMUNION ANTIPHON (Ps 116:12-13)

How can I repay the Lord for all his goodness to me? The chalice of salvation I will raise, and I will call on the name of the Lord.

PRAYER AFTER COMMUNION

O God, who have given to us as spiritual food the saving Sacrament of your Son, which we have offered you in thanksgiving, grant that, being strengthened by gifts of courage and joy, we may serve you more devoutly and be worthy of still further blessings.
Through Christ our Lord. Amen.

MEMORIAL MASS IN HONOUR OF ARCHBISHOP AUGUSTINE OBIORA AKUBUEZE (WHITE)

30 October, 2026

FIRST READING(Phil.1:1-11)

A reading from the letter of St. Paul to the Philippians

The one who began this good work in you will see that it is finished when the Day of Christ Jesus comes.

From Paul and Timothy, servants of Christ Jesus, to all the saints in Christ Jesus, together with their presiding elders and deacons. We wish you the grace and peace of God our Father and of the Lord Jesus Christ.

I thank my God whenever I think of you; and every time I pray for all of you, I pray with joy, remembering how you have helped to spread the Good News from the day you first heard it right up to the present. I am quite certain that the one who began this good work in you will see that it is finished when the Day of Christ Jesus comes. It is only natural that I should feel like this towards you all, since you have shared the privileges which have been mine: both my chains and my work defending and establishing the gospel. You have a permanent place in my heart, and God knows how much I miss you all, loving you as Christ Jesus loves you. My prayer is that your love for each other may increase more and more and never stop improving your knowledge and deepening your perception so that you can always recognize what is best. This will help you to become pure and blameless, and prepare you for the Day of Christ, when you will reach the perfect goodness which Christ Jesus produces in us for the glory and praise of God.

The word of the Lord

Thanks be to God

RESPONSORIAL PSALM

(Ps. 111:1-6)

Response: Great are the works of the Lord.

1. I will thank the Lord with all my heart in the meeting of the just and their assembly. Great are the works of the Lord; to be pondered by all who love them. (R)

2. Majestic and glorious his work, his justice stands firm for ever. He makes us remember his wonders. The Lord is compassion and love. (R)

3. He gives food to those who fear him; keeps his covenant ever in mind. He has shown his might to his people by giving them the lands of the nations.(R)

GOSPEL ACCLAMATION(Jn.10:27)

Alleluia, alleluia! The sheep that belongs to me listen to my voice, says the Lord, I know them and they follow me. **Alleluia!**

GOSPEL (Lk.14:1-6)

A reading from the holy Gospel according to Luke

Which of you here, if his son falls into a well, or his ox, will not pull him put on a Sabbath day?

On a Sabbath day Jesus had gone for a meal to the house of one of the leading Pharisees; and they watched him closely. There in front of him was a man with dropsy, and Jesus addressed the lawyers and Pharisees, 'Is it against the law' he asked 'to cure a man on the Sabbath, or not?' But they remained silent, so he took the man and cured him and sent him away. Then he said to them, 'which of you here, if his son falls into a well, or his ox, will not pull him out on a Sabbath day without hesitation?' And to this they could find no answer.

The Gospel of the Lord

Praise to you, Lord Jesus Christ

BISHOP CANONISTS IN NIGERIA

1. His Eminence, Cardinal Peter Okpaleke - Bishop of Ekwulobia
2. His Lordship, Most Rev. Anthony O. Gbuji - Bishop Emeritus of Enugu
3. His Lordship, Most Rev. Camillus Etokudoh - Bishop Emeritus of Port Harcourt
4. His Grace, Most Rev. Gabriel Leke Abegunrin - Archbishop of Ibadan
5. His Lordship, Most Rev. Hilary Odili Okeke - Bishop Emeritus of Nnewi
6. His Lordship, Most Rev. Gabriel Dunia - Bishop of Auchi
7. His Lordship, Most Rev. Martin Igwe Uzoukwu - Bishop of Minna
8. His Lordship, Most Rev. Solomon Amatu - Bishop of Okigwe
9. His Lordship, Most Rev. Donatus A. Ogun - Bishop of Uromi
10. His Lordship, Most Rev. Jonas Benson Okoye - Bishop of Nnewi
11. His Lordship, Most Rev. Michael Kalu Ukpong - Bishop of Umuahia Diocese
12. His Lordship, Most Rev. Ernest Obodo - Auxiliary Bishop of Enugu Diocese
13. The Late Metropolitan Archbishop of Benin City, Most Rev. Augustine Obiora Akubeze - Archbishop Emeritus of Benin City (1956 – 2026)



List of AWARDEES & HONOURS

A. ROLE OF LAW AWARD

1. His Excellency, Most Rev. Anthony O. Gbuji.
Founder, Canon Law Society of Nigeria (CLSN)

B. AWARD OF FELLOWSHIP

2. His Excellency, Most Rev. Jude Thaddeus Okolo
Apostolic Nuncio to Haiti
3. His Excellency, Most Rev. Brian Ngozi Udaigwe
Apostolic Nuncio to *Ethiopia and Djibouti; Apostolic Delegate to Somalia*
4. His Excellency, Most Rev. Ernest Obodo
Apostolic Administrator of Abakaliki and Auxiliary Bishop of Enugu
5. Very Rev. Msgr. Pius Kii
Senior Lecturer, Faculty of Canon Law, *Catholic Institute of West Africa (CIWA)*
6. Very Rev. Fr. Augustine Ehigie
Vicar General and Judicial Vicar *Archdiocese of Benin City and former CLSN Vice President*
7. Rev. Fr. Emmanuel Faweh Kazah
St. Albert Institute, Fayit-Fadan Kagoma, Kaduna State

C. AWARD OF EXCELLENCE

8. His Excellency, Barr. Dr. Peter Ndubuisi Mbah
Governor of Enugu State

D. MERIT AWARD

9. Very Rev. Msgr. Obiora Ike
10. Rev. Fr. Prof. Dr. Christian Anieke
11. Barr. Patricia Chibogwu Egbuna
12. Prof. Callistus Amu
13. Arc. Stephen Obiekii
14. Prof. Emmanuel Chukwudi Ejim
15. Chief Dr. Anthony Mogboh, J.T., SAN
16. Prof. Frank Okechukwu Ezugwu
17. Dr. James Onuorah Akpeh

ROLE OF LAW AWARD



HIS LORDSHIP, MOST REV.

ANTHONY OKONKWO GBUJI

Emeritus Bishop of Enugu Diocese &
Founder, Canon Law Society of Nigeria

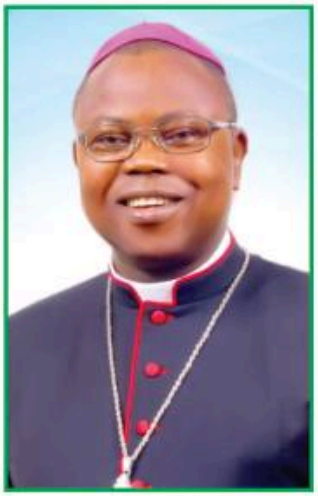
AWARD OF FELLOWSHIP



Most Rev. Jude Thaddeus Okolo
Apostolic Nuncio to Haiti



Most Rev. Brian Ngozi Udaigwe
Apostolic Nuncio to *Ethiopia and Djibouti; Apostolic Delegate to Somalia*



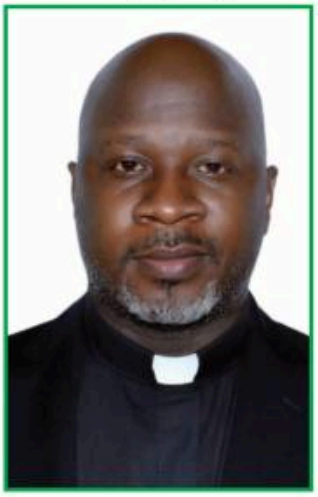
His Excellency, Most Rev. Ernest Obodo
Apostolic Administrator of Abakaliki and Auxiliary Bishop of Enugu



Very Rev. Msgr. Pius Kii
Senior Lecturer, Faculty of Canon Law, *Catholic Institute of West Africa (CIWA)*

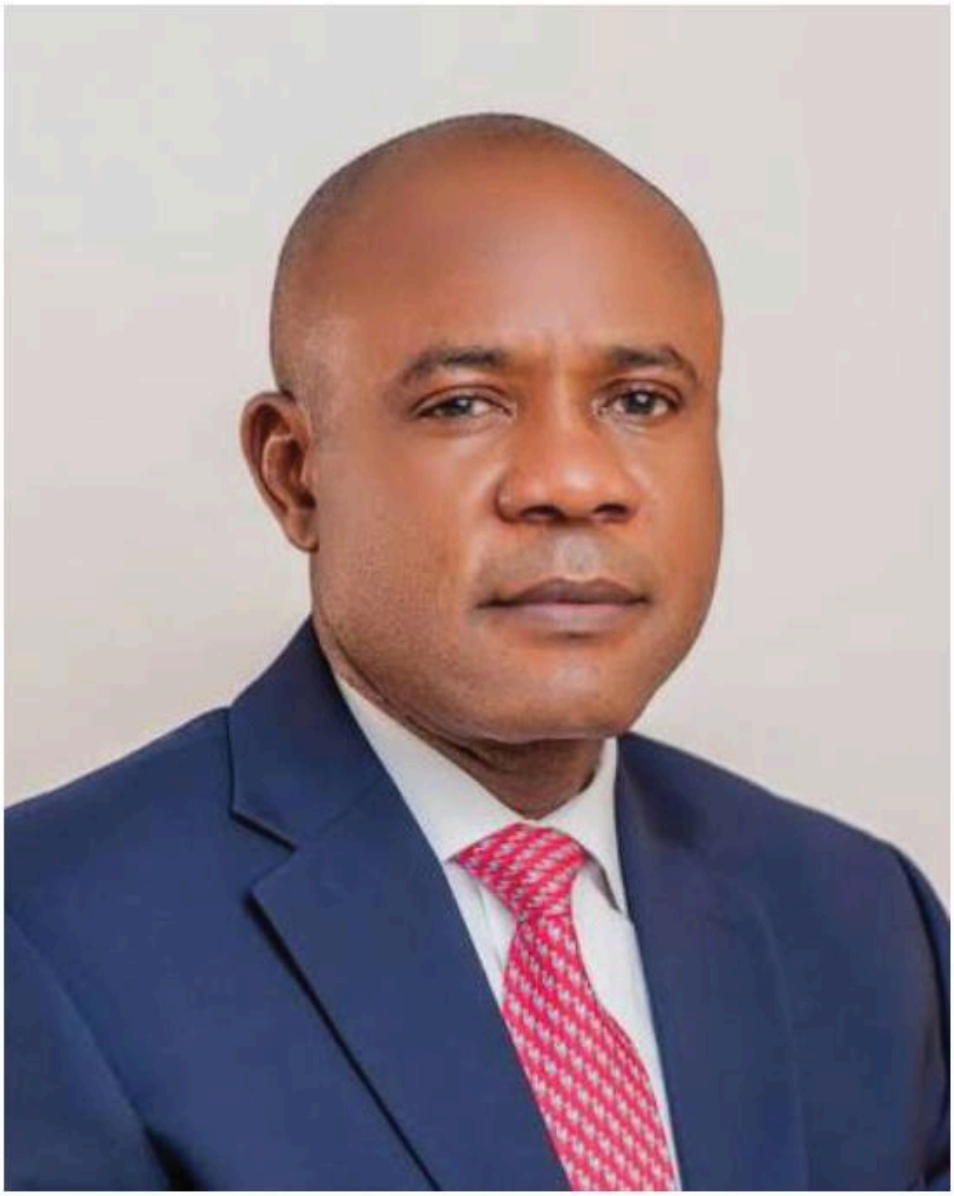


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Rev. Fr. Emmanuel Faweh Kazah
St. Albert Institute, Fayit-Fadan Kagoma, Kaduna State

AWARD OF EXCELLENCE



DR. PETER NDUBUISI MBAH

Executive Governor of Enugu State



MERIT AWARD

VERY REV. MSGR. PROF. OBIORA IKE



Born in Gusau to Richard and Lucy Ike of Umana Ndiagu, Ezeagu, Obiora Ike was formed at All Hallows Seminary, St John Cross Seminary, Nsukka, and Bigard Memorial Seminary, Enugu.
He then studied at the Jesuit College Canisianum in Innsbruck, Austria. He was ordained in 1981 at 25, the youngest priest in the history of the Diocese of Enugu, under the motto of St Paul, "To be all things to all people." He went on to earn doctorates in Philosophy and Jurisprudence and in Catholic Social Ethics at Bonn, and became one of the first Nigerian priests to specialize in Catholic Social Thought.

As first Pastoral Director of a home for the elderly and sick in Cologne, he brought the Daughters of Divine Love to Germany, a mission that now counts over 100 sisters. At home he served as Chaplain of Holy Rosary College, Chairman of the Catholic Commission for Justice and Peace, and Vicar General of Enugu from 1998. In 1999. Pope John Paul II named him a Papal Chamberlain, the youngest Monsignor in Nigeria at the time. He later served as parish priest of St Leo the Great, Trans Ekulu.

On 4 October 1986 he founded the Catholic Institute for Development, Justice, Peace and Caritas (CIDJAP), which promotes Catholic social teaching, empowers communities, and gives legal assistance to prison inmates. As Director of Diocesan Projects, he initiated the Ugwuomu farm, now the permanent site of Godfrey Okoye University.

The author of over 100 books, monographs and journal contributions, he has lectured in Cologne and Tilburg, held a full professorship at Goethe University, Frankfurt, and served as Professor of Ethics and Intercultural Studies at Godfrey Okoye University. He sits on the governing councils of several universities.

He is currently Pro-Chancellor of the State University of Medical and Applied Sciences, Enugu.Servant of State and World. He led the team that secured the return of Catholic schools in 2008, served at the 2014 National Conference, and chaired the Enugu State Economic Advisory Committee. From 2016 to 2023 he was Executive Director of Globethics.net in Geneva. He is President of the Club of Rome, Nigeria Chapter, and a member of the European Academy of Science and Arts. Pope Benedict XVI appointed him an expert to the Synod of Bishops on Africa.A speaker of eleven languages and a champion of justice, human rights and human dignity, Msgr. Ike has been all things to all people for 45 years of priesthood.



MERIT AWARD

VERY REV. FR. PROF. DR. CHRISTIAN ANIEKE



Christian Anieke (born 1 October 1965) is a Nigerian Roman Catholic priest and the founding Vice Chancellor of Godfrey Okoye University, Enugu, Nigeria. Ordained a priest in 2000, he is a professor of English and Literary Studies. From 2006 to 2009, he was Provost of the Institute of Ecumenical Education. He became the Vice Chancellor of Godfrey Okoye University, which is owned by the Catholic Diocese of Enugu in Nigeria, in 2009. He is also the director of the university's Institute of Chinua Achebe Studies.

Christian Anieke's studies and research in Philosophy, Biblical Theology, English and American Studies and English Language have seen him study in Urban University, Rome; the University of Innsbruck, Austria; Bath Language School, Stratford-upon-Avon; Oxford University; and the University of Muenster. He has a B.Sc. in Education and English from the University of Nigeria, Nsukka. At the University of Innsbruck, he graduated summa cum laude from his doctorate program in English and from both of his masters programs in Philosophy and Theology.

He is the author of Chinua Achebe's Trilogy: A Study in Bicultural Communication (2014), Intercultural Problems of Communication: The (Re) Presentation of the Igbo People and Their Culture in Chinua Achebe's Things Fall Apart, Arrow of God and No Longer at Ease (2005), Hybrid Formations in English (2002), The Symbol of the Dove at the Baptism of Christ (2000), and Metaphysics as a Natural Disposition in the Philosophy of Immanuel Kant (1994). He co-authored Frontiers in Education: Advances, Issues and Perspectives(2015), Stories of Peace (2011), Njem Goliver Jere: An Igbo translation of Gulliver's Travels (2009), and A Dictionary of German, English and Igbo (2008).

He is a recipient of the Universal Peace Foundation's Ambassador for Peace Award, the Rotary Club of Maryland's Vocational Gold Service Award of Excellence, the National Association of Grassroots Newspapers Publishers' Eminence Award, the Youth Peace Conference's Peace Champion Award, and the University of Nigeria, Nsukka's Department of Philosophy's Special Award, among several others. A native of Ezeagu, Enugu State, Nigeria, and an honorary citizen of Mitterikirchen, Austria, he is a holder of a chieftaincy title: the Ezeudo Gburu Gburu of Umumba Ndiagu, Enugu State, Nigeria.



AWARD OF FELLOWSHIP

VERY REV. MSGR.
PIUS BARINAADAA KII, PhD.



Very Rev. Msgr. Pius Barinaadaa Kii, PhD, is a Catholic priest of the Diocese of Port Harcourt, Rivers State, Nigeria, and a distinguished canon lawyer, university lecturer, ecclesiastical judge, and public administrator. He holds a doctorate in Canon Law and has dedicated his priestly ministry to ecclesiastical governance, education, judicial administration, institutional development, and public service.

He currently serves as President of the Canon Law Society of West Africa, Judicial Vicar of the Catholic Diocese of Port Harcourt, and Parish Priest of Holy Family Catholic Church, Woji, Port Harcourt. He is also a part-time Senior Lecturer at PAMO University of Medical Sciences, a lecturer in the Department of Canon Law at the Catholic Institute of West Africa (CIWA), and Chairman of the Tenders Board of the Governing Council of Veritas University, Abuja. In addition, he serves as Chaplain of the Chapel of the Assumption at PAMO University of Medic



AWARD OF FELLOWSHIP

REV. FR.

EMMANUEL FAWEH KAZAH, PhD.H



Rev. Fr. Emmanuel Faweh Kazah, PhD, is a Nigerian Catholic priest, canon lawyer, educator, and administrator born on 1 August 1979 in Bauchi State. He hails from Zangon Kataf Local Government Area of Kaduna State, is a native speaker of Hausa, and is fluent in English, Italian, and Spanish.

He received his early education at Gwagwarwa Special Primary School, Kano (First School Leaving Certificate, 1985–1990) and Government College Kaduna (SSCE, 1991–1997). He earned a Bachelor of Philosophy from St. Thomas Aquinas' Major Seminary, Makurdi (2000–2003) and a Bachelor of Divinity from St. Joseph's Major Seminary, Ikot Ekpene (2004–2008). He later obtained a Master's/License and a PhD from the Pontifical Lateran University in Vatican City (2011–2015 and 2015–2018, respectively), along with a Diploma in Canonical Administrative Praxis from the Congregation for the Clergy (2014–2016), a Certificate from the Apostolic Tribunal of the Roman Rota (2014), and a Certificate in Formative Praxis (2017–2018). He also holds a Professional Diploma in Education from Ahmadu Bello University, Zaria (2020–2021) and is currently pursuing an undergraduate degree in Law at the University of Jos (since 2023).

Fr. Kazah has served the Church in both pastoral and academic capacities. Early roles included Liturgist at St. Peter and Paul Propaedeutic Seminary, Eruku; Vice-Rector/Bursar and teacher at St. Charles Borromeo Minor Seminary, Kafanchan; Vocations Director, Associate Pastor, and leadership positions within the Nigerian Catholic Diocesan Priests Association in the Diocese of Kafanchan (2009–2011). From 2011 to 2017 he was Associate Pastor at Parrocchia Sacri Cuori di Gesù e Maria in Frascati, Italy, and Promoter of Justice in the beatification process of Chiara (Silvia).

Since 2017 he has been Rector of St. Albert Institute, Fayit-Fadan Kagoma, Kafanchan (Kaduna State), where he is also a Lecturer I in the Department of Theology and Philosophy (promoted and confirmed in 2020). He teaches Canon Law and Parish Administration and has supervised undergraduate theses on related topics. He has additionally lectured at Good Shepherd Major Seminary (2019–2021). In the Diocese of Kafanchan he serves as Vicar General (Pastoral) since 2020 and is a Member of the Board of Trustees of Christ the King Major Seminary (since 2021). He is Editorial Adviser of the Albertine Journal of Philosophy.

His scholarly work focuses on canon law, ecclesiastical administration, pastoral issues, and governance. He is the author of the book Administrative Acts in the Administration of Temporal Goods: Sources, Analyses and Prospects for the Nigerian Conference of Bishops (Lateran University Press, 2018) and has published articles in peer-reviewed journals and collections on topics including restorative justice in the Church's penal system, the role of pastoral agents in good governance, lay participation in consultative organs, and related subjects. He has attended international and local conferences on canon law, Church reform, and related themes in Rome and Nigeria.



MERIT AWARD

BARR.
PATRICIA CHIBUOGWU EGBUNA



Barr. Patricia Chibuogwu Egbuna is a highly accomplished legal practitioner, human rights defender, and a senior advocate for structural justice within the Nigerian civic space. For decades, she has merged professional legal brilliance with a profound sense of Christian ministry, serving as the Director of Legal Services and Head of the Legal Team at the Catholic Institute for Development, Justice and Peace (CIDJAP) in Enugu, Nigeria.

Academic Background & Qualifications

Bachelor of Laws (LL.B. Hons.) – Faculty of Law, University of Nigeria, Nsukka (UNN). A rigorous foundation in jurisprudence, criminal law, and human rights advocacy.

Barrister-at-Law (B.L.) – The Nigerian Law School. Formally called to the Nigerian Bar, licensing her as a Solicitor and Advocate of the Supreme Court of Nigeria.

Bachelor of Science (B.Sc.) in Psychology – Providing her with a deep, scientific understanding of human behavior, trauma, and mental wellness, which heavily informs her empathetic approach to legal defense and client counseling.

Nigeria Certificate in Education (NCE) in Fine & Applied Arts – Grounding her early professional development in creative problem-solving, structural design, and visual communication.

Professional Experience & Core Milestones

Director of Legal Services, CIDJAP (Enugu Diocese): Directs the pro-bono defense strategies for indigent, vulnerable, and marginalized clients seeking equity in the civil courts.

Expert in Mediation & Alternative Dispute Resolution (ADR): Utilizes extensive seminar training in Mediation, ADR, and Arbitration to settle sensitive community, marital, and land disputes out of court, preserving communal harmony and offering swift justice without the financial strain of protracted litigation.

Prison De-congestion Advocate: Regularly visits maximum and medium-security correctional facilities across Enugu State to interview inmates, trace lost case files, secure bail dockets, and obtain records of proceedings—effectively restoring liberty to hundreds of unjustly detained or forgotten individuals.

Champion of Widows' Rights & Gender Justice: Actively coordinates strategic interventions against discriminatory customary practices, shielding grieving widows from unlawful disinheritance, property dispossession, and socioeconomic alienation.

Diocesan & Inter-NGO Consultant: Serves as a vital link formatting structural synergy between the canonical missions of the Church and local civil society networks to anchor systemic justice, peace, and human dignity.

Professional Memberships & Associations

Member, Nigerian Bar Association (NBA) – Enugu Branch.

Member, International Federation of Women Lawyers (FIDA) – Nigeria Chapter.

Member, Catholic Justice, Development, and Peace Commission (JDPC) network.

Affiliated Legal Practitioner, Network of Civil Society Organizations (CSOs) in South-East Nigeria.



MERIT AWARD

PROF.
OKWUDILI CALISTUS AMU



Prof. Okwudili Calistus Amu is a Consultant Urologist and Endourologist who combines clinical practice, medical education, professional training and research. He lectures in the Department of Surgery, College of Medicine, University of Nigeria, and provides specialist urological care at the University of Nigeria Teaching Hospital (UNTH), Ituku-Ozalla, Enugu, Nigeria.

With over 25 years of clinical and academic experience in Urology, Prof. Amu has built a distinguished career in specialist patient care, Endourology, medical education and research. His work focuses on improving the management of urological conditions while contributing to the development of medical professionals and specialist healthcare capacity.

He serves as the Medical Director of Micdella Urology Hospital, Enugu, where he leads the provision of specialised urological services and promotes patient-centred care.
His clinical and research interests include benign prostatic hyperplasia, lower urinary tract symptoms, transurethral prostate surgery, urethral strictures, prostate assessment and other areas of urological and surgical practice. His research has examined key aspects of the assessment, treatment, and outcomes of patients with these conditions, with publications in the Nigerian Journal of Clinical Practice and other medical journals.

Prof. Amu has also made a significant contribution to training and mentoring doctors in Endourology. He has facilitated Endourology training and continues to equip medical practitioners with specialised knowledge and skills relevant to contemporary urological practice.

His contribution to healthcare extends beyond specialist practice. As a resource person on prostate health, he has facilitated educational sessions for diverse groups, sharing evidence-based knowledge on prostate-related conditions and promoting greater awareness of prostate health within the wider community.

Beyond his professional life, Prof. Amu is a devoted Christian, husband and father of five. His faith, family and commitment to service remain central to his life. Outside medicine and academia, he enjoys swimming and watching movies.

Prof. Okwudili Calistus Amu's career reflects a sustained commitment to clinical excellence, medical education, professional mentorship, research, leadership and service. Through his work as a clinician, educator, trainer, and researcher, he continues to advance urological care and develop the next generation of medical professionals.



MERIT AWARD

ARC. STEPHEN OBIEKII



Arc. Stephen Obiekii, is a distinguished Nigerian Architect, Project Management Consultant, and the Chief Executive Officer of Manu Deii Consult, a reputable architectural and construction consultancy dedicated to excellence, innovation, and sustainable infrastructure development.

An Architect with many years of professional practice. Throughout his career, he has successfully designed, supervised, and managed numerous residential, commercial, educational, institutional, and ecclesiastical projects across Nigeria.

His professional experience spans major developments in Enugu, Lagos, and Abuja. His portfolio includes residential projects at Chevron Drive, Carlton gate Estate, Lekki phase 2, Lagos, projects associated with Bridges & Hammers, Life Camp, Abuja, and numerous private and institutional developments within Enugu State.

Among his notable achievements are his role as Project Architect for the successful completion of Aracile Aid Foundation Academy, Obeagu, Enugu State, the delivery of May Blossom High School, and several other educational and residential developments. He is presently overseeing the NERAM Project at Umuode for the Catholic Diocese, where he continues to contribute his professional expertise to the Church's infrastructural growth.

Beyond his professional accomplishments, Arc. Obiekii is a devoted Catholic and an active Church leader. He currently serves as the Chairman of the Catholic Men Organisation (CMO) of St. Mary's Parish Uwani, Enugu. where he provides dedicated leadership and actively promotes initiatives that strengthen the spiritual, social, and developmental life of the parish community.

Widely respected for his integrity, humility, professionalism, and unwavering commitment to excellence, Arc. Obiekii believes that architecture is a vocation that combines creativity with service to humanity. His work continues to reflect his passion for quality, ethical practice, and sustainable development.

In recognition of his outstanding professional achievements, exemplary leadership, and dedicated infrastructural support to the Church and society, he was appointed a recipient of the Canon Law Society of Nigeria (CLSN) Merit Award of Excellence in 2026.

He remains committed to advancing the architectural profession, mentoring emerging professionals, promoting ethical standards, and using his God-given talents in the service of God, humanity, and national development.



MERIT AWARD

PROF. EMMANUEL EJIM



Emmanuel was born on the 22nd of July 1971 at Nsukka in Enugu State, Nigeria, and proceeded to Central Schoool II Nsukka where he obtained the First School Leaving Certificate in 1982, and later to Nsukka High School where he obtained the Senior Secondary School Certificate in 1988.

He had his undergraduate medical education at the College of Medicine, University of Nigeria, and obtained the MBBS certificate in 1995, with distinctions in Human Anatomy and Medical Biochemistry.

Housemanship and National Youth Service were in 1995/96 and 1996/97 respectively. Emma worked as a Medical Officer at Mother of Mercy Hospital, Ihe in Awgu LGA of Enugu State from 1997 to 1999.

Postgraduate medical training was at the University of Nigeria Teaching hospital and National Postgraduate Medical College of Nigeria from 1999 to 2005 when he obtained a Fellowship of the National Postgraduate Medical College in Internal Medicine/Cardiology.

He was appointed a Consultant Physician/Cardiologist at the University of Nigeria Teaching hospital in 2006, and later in 2011, was appointed a Senior lecturer in the Department of Medicine, University of Nigeria. He was promoted to the rank of an Associate Professor of Medicine in October 2014, and to a full Professor in October 2017.

Emma had further training in Cardiology at the UZ Gasthuisberg Leuven Belgium, and at the Aarhus University HospitalS Denmark.

Currently he has over 60 publications in peer review journals.

Emmanuel is a native of Ogwofia Owa in Ezeagu LGA of Enugu state, and is married with children.

He is an Active Member of Ark of Covenant Praesidium, Legio Mariae at the Holy Family Chaplaincy, University of Nigeria Teaching Hospital Old Site Enugu.



MERIT AWARD

BARR.
ANTHONY OBINNA MOGBOH JNR. SAN



Mogboh Anthony Obinna Jnr, SAN, is a distinguished legal practitioner whose career spans more than three decades of service to the law, to business and to the Nigerian public. He began his working life in 1992 as a Credit Officer at Afribank Nigeria Plc, Port Harcourt, before building a career at the Bar. From 2001 to 2014 he served as Managing Solicitor of Mogboh Offiah & Co (Barristers and Solicitors, Arbitrators), and since June 2014 he has led the Law Firm of Mogboh & Co (Legal Consultants) in Enugu.

His legal expertise covers corporate, commercial and land law, foreign direct investments, divestments and regulatory compliance. Beyond the courtroom, he is a respected consultant and reformer, providing technical assistance and skills development in land administration, human rights, leadership values, democracy, governance and electoral reform. He has also contributed to the design and implementation of public and private land policy and to government policy dialogue. Since August 1993 he has served as Director, Project Supervisor and Acquisitions Manager of Chinyelu Properties Limited, bringing project strategy, planning and organizational change management to the property sector.

Service to the Profession and Community
He has served the Nigerian Bar Association faithfully at branch and national levels: as Social Secretary of the Enugu Branch (2006–2008), Chairman of the Law Week Dinner Committee (2013), a member of the Human Rights Committee (2004–2006), a member of the national Data Base Committee (2014–2016), and NEC Representative for Enugu ENBAR (2010–2012). He chairs Zontax Zeal Ltd, a guarantee NGO devoted to societal values, democracy, governance and human dignity. He is Legal Adviser to Bankson Bureau De Change, the Enugu State Water Tankers Association and the Ogwofia Ozom General Assembly, and was National Secretary of the Ogwofia Youths Assembly.

Commitment to the Bar
His record of conference participation reflects an enduring commitment to professional growth and to the wider legal community. He has attended eight International Bar Association conferences across the world, from Rio de Janeiro (1983, as an observer) to Durban, Buenos Aires, Madrid, Vancouver, Dubai, Washington DC and Tokyo (2014). He has also been a regular presence at the NBA Annual Conferences, from Calabar in 2001 to Owerri in 2014 and Abuja in 2015.



MERIT AWARD

PROF.

FRANK OKECHUKWU EZUGWU



Professor Ezugwu Frank Okechukwu is a Distinguished Professor of Obstetrics and Gynecology and the Emeritus Provost of the College of Medicine at the Enugu State University of Science and Technology. Born in Opi, Nsukka, he began his academic journey with a Distinction at the First School Leaving Certificate and eventually acquired his MB;BS from the University of Maiduguri with a Distinction in Microbiology.
Throughout a career spanning over four decades, Professor Ezugwu has established himself as a leading medical authority and administrator.

CLINICAL EXCELLENCE: He is a Fellow of the West African College of Surgeons (FWACS), a Fellow of the International College of Surgeons (FICS), a member International Federation of Obstetrics and Gynecology (FIGO) and holds a Diploma in Endoscopy and Minimal Access Surgery.

ACADEMIC LEADERSHIP: Since 2012, he has served as a Professor of Obstetrics and Gynecology at the ESUT; a Trainer and Examiner in both undergraduate and post-graduate Medicine to many medical schools and the West African College of Surgeons. He has held pivotal roles including the Headship of the Department of Obstetrics and Gynecology ESUT ; Dean of the Faculty of Clinical Medicine , ESUT and Provost of the ESUT College of Medicine with the status of a Deputy Vice Chancellor.

ADMINISTRATIVE IMPACT: He served as the Pioneer Chairman, Medical Advisory Committee (C-MAC) of the ESUT Teaching Hospital, Principal Officer and member of the Management Committee of ESUT and member, Governing Council of ESUT. He was the Chairman, Southeast Governors' Forum Consultative Committee on Health amidst other adhoc appointments.

PROFESSIONAL SERVICE: He had chaired the Society of Obstetrics and Gynecology of Nigeria (SOGON) Enugu State and currently chairs the Board of Trustees for the Medical and Dental Consultants Association of Nigeria, ESUT Chapter amidst membership of Boards of Trustees of various organizations including the Nigerian Medical Association Enugu (previous) and Carmelites Prisoners Interest Organization (CAPIO). Beyond his professional accolades, Professor Ezugwu is the Founder and Director of St. Patricks Hospital and Maternity, Enugu at 6 Ogbaru street Independence Layout Enugu, to the glory of God. The hospital has left impeccable and indelible record in Maternal and Child Health and has recently been upgraded to many specialized clinical and diagnostic care. He is a 4th-degree Knight of the Order of St. Mulumba and a dedicated philanthropist known for supporting rural health facilities and indigent children. He is happily married to Dr. Mrs. Bernadine Chinyere Ezugwu, a retired Permanent Secretary of Enugu State with whom he shares five children and six grandchildren. Prof Ezugwu Frank dedicates this award to Mother Mary (Our Lady of Perpetual Help and Mediatrix of all Graces).



MERIT AWARD

DR. JAMES ONUORAH AKPEH



Dr. James Onuorah Akpeh is a devout Catholic who was confirmed by Cardinal Francis Arinze the then Archbishop of Onitsha in 1977 at the age of 9 years at St. Theresa's Catholic church Umueze- Anam. His early education was at the Central school and the Community Primary school Umueze- Anam. He Started his secondary education at the Community Secondary school Umueze- Anam but left the school in class four and completed the program at Father Joseph Memorial High school Aguleri.

He proceeded to the University of Nigeria Nsukka in 1990, where he studied Medicine and Surgery. He bagged the fellowship of the National Postgraduate Medical College of Nigeria in Otorhinolaryngology, Head and Neck Surgery (ENT) in 2012.

He is currently working as a Consultant at the University of Nigeria Teaching Hospital and a Senior lecturer at the College of Medicine, University of Nigeria, Ituku-Ozalla Campus. He is the Deputy director of Hostel and Accommodation at the University of Nigeria. He was two-term, Head of the department of Otorhinolaryngology at UNN/ UNTH. He is also a member of the UNN Senate entrance board and equally sits at the board of the Nigerian Academy of Audiology as well as the Faculty board of the Otorhinolaryngology, Head and Neck Surgery of the National Postgraduate Medical College of Nigeria.

Dr. Akpeh James Onuorah is a visiting consultant to the Enugu State University of Science and Technology Teaching Hospital, Parklane, Enugu and the National Orthopaedic Hospital, Enugu. He was formerly a Consultant and head of Otorhinolaryngology at the Chukwuemeka Odimegwu Ojukwu University, Awka, and a visiting Consultant to the Federal Medical centre Owerri, Imo State. He had served the Nigerian Medical Association, Enugu State as the Chairman of the Continue Medical Education and the Anti- Quackery Committee.

In the church Dr Akpeh James is the current vice-president of the Catholic Men's Organisation of the Holy Trinity parish, Independence layout, Enugu. He is the Enugu Deanery Coordinator of the Catholic Charismatic Renewal in Nigeria, the Secretary National Medical Commission of the CCRN, and also the Chairman of the same Commission at the Onitsha Ecclestical Province and the Enugu Diocesan CCRN.

He was one time the General Coordinator of the God's Delight Catholic Charismatic Renewal, Reunion fellowship UNEC and have in several years with this group partnered with the Catholic Bishops of Enugu, Most Rev. Dr. CVC Onaga in his pastoral duties in taking medical missions to the underserved in the hither land.

Dr. James Onuorah Akpeh is happily married to his heart throb, Mrs Caroline Onyetorochi Akpeh who is also a Charismatic and the marriage is blessed with six special children. They recently celebrated their Sliver jubilee wedding anniversary.

THE ROLE OF THE CHURCH IN GOVERNANCE

Inaugural Paper presented on the occasion of the 38th Annual convention of the Canon Law society of Nigeria CLSN

INTRODUCTION

The good news of salvation requires that the Church be present in the world. Christ, our Saviour, "desires all men to be saved and to come to the knowledge of the truth" (1 Tim 2:4). The Church, sharing in mankind's joys and hopes, in its anxieties and sadness, stands with every man and woman of every place and time, to bring them the good news of the Kingdom of God, which in Jesus Christ has come and continues to be present among them. For this reason, the Church is not indifferent to what is decided, brought about or experienced in society; she is attentive to the moral quality, that is, the authentically human and humanizing aspects of social life.

The terminology: **Rerum Novarum** means "of revolutionary change/new things" and was promulgated by Pope Leo XIII in 1891. It is foundational to modern Catholic social teaching. The paper makes an important distinction: Christ is King, but the Church's mission is not to establish a theocratic State. The Kingdom of God is already present in Christ and the Church yet awaits its fullness. The Church therefore enters public life principally through proclamation of the Gospel, formation of conscience, social action, and the defence of human dignity.

This paper examines the role of the Church in governance through the theological vision of Christ as ***Rex Regum***, King of Kings. Governance is ultimately a question about the human person: who the person is, what the person is worth, what government exists to accomplish, and what limits ought to constrain the exercise of public authority. Where the human person is reduced to a voter, taxpayer, consumer, ethnic subject, political supporter or economic unit, governance inevitably becomes vulnerable to manipulation, exclusion and abuse. The Catholic Church approaches governance from a fundamentally different starting point: the human person is created in the image and likeness of God, possesses an intrinsic and inviolable dignity, and is ordered towards communion with God and others.

The Church's role in governance is neither political domination nor institutional withdrawal. Rather, it is a mission of evangelization, formation of conscience and defence. The church is not simply a religious association attempting to secure influence within the political sphere. She is the sacrament of salvation, the sign and instrument of unity, communion with God and entire church. The Church contributes to governance by helping society recover the truth that every authority is from God **(Romans 13 verse 1)** and exists for the human person and the common good. The crisis of governance is frequently described in institutional language: corruption, weak institutions, electoral malpractice, insecurity, poor public services, abuse of power, poverty and declining public trust. Yet beneath these institutional failures lies a deeper crisis, a crisis concerning the human person the crisis of sin. *But this world crisis is a crisis of saints*.

The Christian proclamation begins with a radically different sovereignty: Jesus Christ is Lord **(Phillipians 2:11).** Thus the proclamation of Christ as Rex Regum: King of Kings, places every earthly authority under a higher moral horizon. Yet Christ's kingship is radically different from the domination exercised by worldly rulers. His throne is the Cross; His authority is expressed in service; and His greatness manifested, in self-giving love.

REX REGUM: CHRIST AND THE NEW KINGDOM

The Christian understanding of governance begins with Christ. Scripture declares in **1 Timothy 6:15: "King of kings, and Lord of lords."** Yet Christ expressly rejected the worldly conception of political domination. When His disciples disputed about greatness, Christ taught: "Whosoever will be great among you, shall be your minister." The Christian concept of authority therefore begins with service. The Church is not simply a religious association attempting to secure influence within the political sphere. She is the sacramental community called to proclaim the Kingdom of God.

RERUM NOVARUM: THE CHURCH ENTERS THE SOCIAL QUESTION

When Pope Leo XIII promulgated Rerum Novarum in 1891, he confronted a society transformed by industrialisation, economic inequality, exploitation of labour and the concentration of wealth.It demonstrated that the Church cannot proclaim the dignity of the human person while remaining indifferent to the social structures that either protect or violate that dignity. The Compendium of the Social Doctrine of the Church (Libreria Editrice Vaticana, Vatican City 2004) para 160 identifies four foundational principles:the dignity of the human person, the common good, subsidiarity and solidarity. The human person is never a means merely to another person's or institution's end. Every person possesses an intrinsic dignity because every person is created in the image and likeness of God. The Compendium identifies the inviolable dignity of the human person as the foundation of the Church's social doctrine. It further states that the person is not merely a passive object of social life but its subject, foundation and goal. This has direct consequences for governance. A government exists for persons, laws exist for persons, courts exist for persons, public institutions exist for persons, even the economy exists for persons. Political authority therefore becomes morally illegitimate when it systematically sacrifices persons to institutional interests.The question that every public policy should answer is therefore: ***What does this policy do to the dignity of the human person?*** **The relevance of this principle to Nigeria is striking.**

Section 17 of the Constitution of the Federal Republic of Nigeria 1999 expressly provides that the Nigerian social order is founded on freedom, equality and justice. It further states that the sanctity of the human person shall be recognised, human dignity maintained and enhanced, governmental actions humane, and exploitation prevented where it is not for the good of the community.

The constitutional language is remarkably consonant with the fundamental concern of this social doctrine. It envisions governance ordered towards human welfare. The Church, however, approaches the issue from an even deeper foundation***: dignity is not granted by government.*** Government does not manufacture human dignity, the legislature does not create it, our judiciary does not create it, a constitution does not create it. Human dignity in fact, precedes the State. The State can recognise it, protect it or violate it, but it cannot ultimately confer it.
That distinction is crucial.
If dignity comes from the State, the State can take it away.
If dignity comes from the nature of the human person created by God, the State is then under an obligation to protect it. This brings us to a particularly important question for the Church in Nigeria:

What exactly is the Church's role in governance?
The answer must begin with a necessary distinction.
The Church is not the State, the state is not the Church.

The Church does not possess a mandate to capture political power nor should she become an appendage of political parties. *My kingdom is not of this world*
The Second Vatican Council expressly teaches that the Church is not identified with the political community or bound to any political system. Rather, she is a safeguard of the transcendent character of the human person. History has taught of how much harm it can do.
This distinction is essential.
The Church's role is therefore primarily formative, pastoral and social, rather than partisan.
The Church speaks truth to power because she is not created by power, She can commend good governance without becoming the government, She can criticise injustice without becoming an opposition party, She can defend human rights without becoming a political movement, She can encourage public officials without becoming their political machinery. This independence is one of the Church's greatest contributions to public life.

ROLE OF THE CHURCH IN FORMATION OF GOVERNANCE
Throughout Scripture, the prophetic tradition demonstrates that religious faith cannot be separated from questions of justice. The prophets confronted kings; Nathan confronted David, Elijah confronted Ahab, John the Baptist confronted Herod, Christ confronted structures of hypocrisy and oppression. Christ in the middle of the passion presents us with an iconic scene a dialogue with Pilate that led him to ask difficult questions …***"truth what is truth"***
The Church inherits this prophetic responsibility.
Her prophetic ministry requires her to ask the uncomfortable questions:
Who speaks for the poor? Who protects the vulnerable? Who defends the voiceless? Who ensures that the law serves justice rather than merely power?
And the Church has not just the task of asking questions, but doing something within its means.
Romans 15:26 (KJV): "or it hath pleased them of Macedonia and Achaia to make a certain contribution for the poor saints which are at Jerusalem."
Acts 11:29 (KJV): "Then the disciples, every man according to his ability, determined to send relief unto the brethren which dwelt in Judaea." A Church that refuses to ask these questions risks reducing Christianity to private spirituality.

Pope Francis has similarly emphasised that the Church has a public role extending beyond charitable and educational activities and that she cannot renounce the political dimension of life where the common good and integral human development are concerned. One of the most important but frequently overlooked contributions of the Church to governance is formation. Good governance ultimately depends upon good citizens all round. Jesus said to the pharisees in **Matthew 23:23 (KJV): "Woe unto you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! for ye pay tithe of mint and anise and cummin, and have omitted the weightier matters of the law, judgment, mercy, and faith: these ought ye to have done, and not to leave the other undone."**

A Christian who learns that every human being bears the image of God should find it increasingly difficult to justify bribery, electoral violence, ethnic discrimination, exploitation or abuse of public office.
This is why the social doctrine of the church cannot remain in books but must rather, become a way of life. The church leaders at every tier should not take this lightly. Our Priests are to normalize the good habit of revisiting Scriptural principles for everything affair. As it is written in **Rom 10:14(KJV) "...and how shall they believe in him of whom they have not heard? and how shall they hear without a preacher?"**
The first way in which society can be influenced with the help of the Church's social doctrine is to

disseminate these teachings of the Church that have been referenced earlier. The second aspect is to underline the ways in which these teachings can be applied in practice, and the third way of influencing society is in a more markedly professional or academic way.. Often it will be necessary to confront new problems that have not arisen in the past. Faithful who are experts in the different social fields (economics, politics, media, education, etc) will need to propose ways to solve them that heed the Church's social teaching.

SUBSIDIARITY: GOVERNANCE FROM THE PERSON UPWARDS

Rerum Novarum, the landmark social encyclical of the Catholic Church issued by Pope Leo XIII on 15 May 1891, offers a particularly important insight into public authority, public office is a trust. The official who controls public resources is a steward, not an owner. This principle is particularly relevant in developing democracies. A healthy state does not seek to control everything, It rather, creates conditions in which persons and communities can flourish. The Church herself embodies this principle through her network of schools, hospitals, charitable institutions, associations and other communities. Our Governance becomes stronger when citizens are not merely recipients of government services but active participants in social development.

The Church does not teach Christians to withdraw from political life. On the contrary, participation in public life can be an expression of Christian responsibility.
This means that the Christian politician has a vocation.
The Christian civil servant has a vocation.
The Christian judge has a vocation.
The Christian lawyer has a vocation.
The Christian academic has a vocation.
The Christian journalist has a vocation.
The question is therefore not simply:
"Can Christians participate in politics?" The better question is: "What kind of politics should a Christian pursue?"
The answer must be politics ordered towards the common good.
It is however worthy of note that the prophetic credibility of the Church is strengthened when her internal life reflects the principles she proclaims. The ***Pontifical Council for Justice and Peace, Compendium of the Social Doctrine of the Church presented at the Vatican on 2 April 2004,*** states that the Church's social doctrine is concerned with the quality of social life because society concerns the human person, and it identifies the promotion of human dignity as a central task of the Church and the lay faithful. Therefore, the Nigerian Church must move from merely responding to social crises towards helping form the culture that produces good governance.

THE NEW KINGDOM: A DIFFERENT MODEL OF POWER

What, then, does "a new kingdom" mean?
It does not mean replacing the Nigerian Republic with a theocracy. It is a kingdom in which power becomes service, the poor become persons rather than statistics, the opponent becomes a person whose dignity remains inviolable, and the human person becomes the centre of social concern. The contemporary relevance of the Church's social doctrine is powerfully demonstrated in ***Fratelli Tutti*** an encyclical letter of Pope Francis, published on 3 October 2020, on the theme of human fraternity and social friendship.

Pope Francis argues that authentic politics must be directed towards the common good and presents political activity as capable of becoming an expression of charity when it works to transform social structures and conditions, a solid movement from compassion towards transformation.

The deeper message is conversion. The problem is not only corrupt politicians, but corrupt culture. Our society cannot consistently condemn corruption in government while tolerating dishonesty in private life.
The new Kingdom, the Rerum Novarum we seek as a church, begins with the conversion of the human heart, but it does not end there. Converted people must also seek the transformation of social structures.

THE ROLE OF THE LAITY IN GOVERNANCE
The lay faithful occupy a unique position in this mission.
The priest has a pastoral mission, the bishop has an episcopal responsibility, the canon lawyer has a juridical vocation, but the Catholic layperson who serves in government, law, medicine, business, academia, media or civil society enters directly into the temporal order. If the Church is to make a meaningful contribution to governance, the Church must ensure that she does not become what she criticizes. When ecclesial platforms become political campaign platforms, the spread of the Gospel suffers. The church must remember at all times, that her loyalty is to Christ.

The ultimate contribution of Catholic social doctrine to governance can therefore be summarised in one proposition: Governance must become human again. This means:
A justice system that sees a person before a case number.
A prison system that sees a person before an inmate number.
A hospital that sees a patient before a statistic.
A government that sees a citizen before a voter.
A public servant who sees office as stewardship rather than entitlement.
A Church that sees the blood of christ running through the vein of each person.
This is what the dignity of the human person demands.

CONCLUSION
More than a century later, the Church's social doctrine has developed into a coherent body of principles centred upon the dignity of the human person, the common good, subsidiarity and solidarity. The contemporary challenge is to translate these principles into the realities of governance. Nigeria does not merely need new policies, rather leaders who are well formed and struggle to acquire the virtues and practice them.

The Church is to announce a Kingdom whose King is Christ, forms consciences according to the Gospel, defend the dignity of every human person, form citizens for service and stand with the poor and vulnerable.

"Pure religion and undefiled before God and the Father is this, To visit the fatherless and widows in their affliction, and to keep himself unspotted from the world." James 1:27

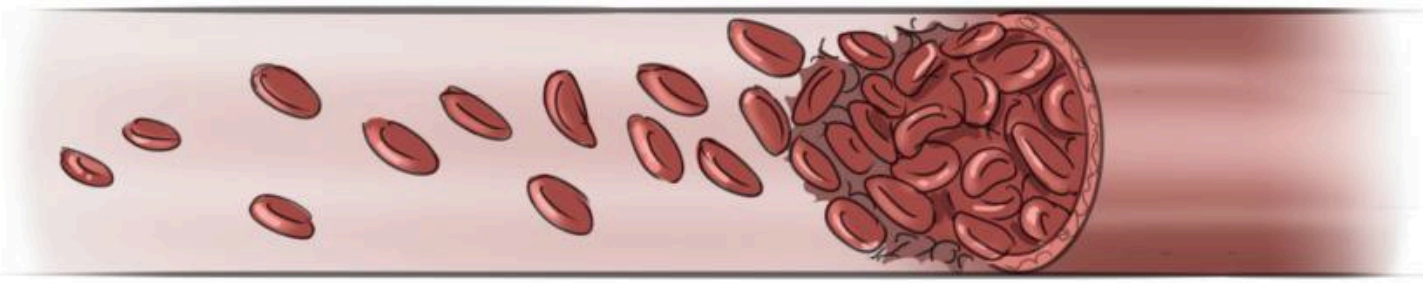
The Church's task, therefore, is to keep reminding the world of this truth, and to embody it.

IKECHUKWU ONUOMA, SAN
Managing Partner
Obra Legal LP

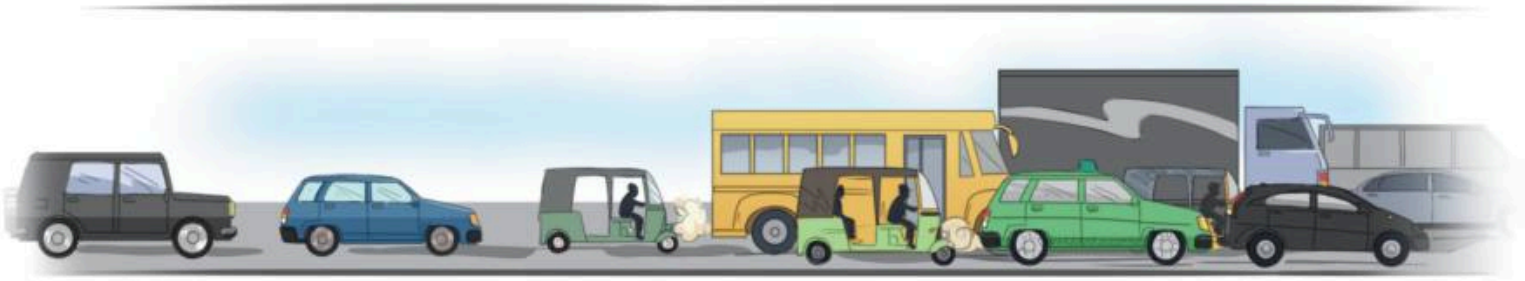
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CANON LAW SOCIETY OF NIGERIA (CLSN)

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MOST REV. ANTHONY OKONKWON GBUJI
Emeritus Bishop of Enugu
Your Lordship,

Happy 95th Birthday!

With hearts full of gratitude to God, we warmly congratulate Your Lordship on the joyful occasion of your 95th birthday on 29 October 2026.

This year, the Canon Law Society of Nigeria (CLSN) deliberately chose Enugu as the venue for its 38th Annual Convention so that we could celebrate this remarkable milestone with you in a special way. As the founding father of our Society, you have been much more than a pioneer; you have been an inspiration, mentor, and guiding light to generations of canonists, priests, and Church leaders in Nigeria. Your vision gave birth to a society that continues to flourish, and your example has encouraged countless people to serve the Church with wisdom, fidelity, and dedication.

It is therefore a great joy for us to honor you in a manner worthy of your outstanding contribution to the Church and to the development of canon law in our country. As a tribute to your rich canonical, academic, and pastoral legacy, we have published a Festschrift containing more than twenty-three scholarly contributions. Among these is an article by His Eminence, Francis Cardinal Arinze, with whom Your Lordship shares the grace of the same priestly ordination date, together with contributions from bishops, priests, religious, and canonists. These essays are not merely academic reflections; they are heartfelt expressions of appreciation for a life that has touched so many and continues to inspire all who have had the privilege of knowing you and benefiting from your ministry.

We are deeply grateful to the Bishop of Enugu, Most Rev. Callistus Onaga, for graciously hosting this convention. We also appreciate the dedicated efforts of the Local Organizing Committee under the leadership of Most Rev. Ernest Obodo, Auxiliary Bishop of Enugu and Apostolic Administrator of Abakaliki Diocese, assisted by Very Rev. Fr. Emeka Nwonye, Judicial Vicar of Enugu, whose commitment has helped make this celebration possible.

Your Lordship, as we celebrate this blessed milestone, we thank Almighty God for the gift of your life, your priesthood, your episcopal ministry, and your tireless service to the Church. We thank Him for the wisdom, kindness, faith, and pastoral zeal that have distinguished your ministry over the decades. Many of us have been personally enriched by your counsel, encouraged by your example, and inspired by your unwavering love for the Church.

May the Lord continue to bless you with good health, peace of mind, and abundant joy. May He reward your years of faithful service with His continued grace, and may He grant us many more years to benefit from your wisdom, experience, and fatherly presence among us.

Ad multos annos!

With deepest respect, affectionate gratitude, and warm felicitations,

Yours sincerely in Christ,

Rev. Fr. Edwin Nosakhare Omorogbe
President, Canon Law Society of Nigeria

Rev. Fr. Charles Essien
Secretary, Canon Law Society of Nigeria

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DIOCESAN CATHOLIC SECRETARIATE
P. O. BOX 302
ENUGU
ENUGU STATE
NIGERIA

15 October, 2026

His Lordship
Most Rev. Anthony O. Gbuji
The Emeritus Bishop of Enugu Diocese
Villa Maria
Enugu State

Your Excellency,

95 HEARTY CHEERS!

I write, on behalf of the Clergy, Religious, and Lay Faithful of the Catholic Diocese of Enugu, to congratulate you on the joyous occasion of your 95th Birthday. This remarkable milestone is an occasion to thank God for the gift of your life, the richness of your episcopal ministry, and the enduring contributions you have made to the growth and mission of the Church.

As Emeritus Bishop of Enugu, your years of pastoral leadership remain an important part of the spiritual heritage of our Diocese. Your passion for the New Evangelisation and your commitment to bringing the Gospel into the realities of contemporary life reflect a shepherd deeply devoted to Christ's mandate to make disciples of all nations (Mat 28:19-20). As the Founder of the Canon Law Society of Nigeria (CLSN), you demonstrated remarkable foresight in promoting canonical scholarship and its importance in the life and governance of the Church. It is particularly fitting that the Society you founded celebrates its 38th Annual Convention alongside this significant milestone in your life. The continued growth of the Society stands as a testament to your vision and a lasting contribution to the Church in Nigeria, reflecting how an initiative born of dedication can continue to serve generations.

At ninety-five, your life remains a testimony of God's sustaining grace and the fruitfulness of a vocation faithfully lived. AS the Psalmist declares. "They shall still bear fruit in old age, they shall be fresh and flourishing (Ps&lm 92:14). Your legacy of pastoral service, evangclisation, and canonical formation continues to bear fruit, reminding us that a life generously offered to God leaves an impact that transcends the years of active ministry. AS you celebrate this special occasion, may the Lord continue to strengthen you with His peace, bless you with good health, and fill, your heart with the joy of His abiding presence. **Amen.**

Fraternally yours in Christ,

Callistus V. C Onaga
BISHOP OF ENUGU

CATHOLIC DIOCESE OF ENUGU

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DIOCESAN CATHOLIC SECRETARIATE
P. O. BOX 302
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ENUGU STATE
NIGERIA

15 October, 2026

His Lordship
Most Rev. Anthony O. Gbuji
The Emeritus Bishop of Enugu Diocese
Villa Maria
Enugu State

Your Excellency,

HEARTFELT CONGRATULATIONS!

I write, on behalf of the Clergy, Religious, and Lay Faithful of the Catholic Diocese of Enugu, to warmly congratulate the Canon Law Society of Nigeria (CLSN) on the occasion of its **38th Annual Convention**, scheduled to take place from 27 to 30 October 2026 at the Holy Ghost Cathedral, Enugu.

This annual gathering offers a valuable opportunity to deepen the Church's understanding of her legal tradition and to reflect on the indispensable role of Canon Law in safeguarding ecclesial communion, promoting justice, and ensuring the orderly governance of the People of God. Far from being merely a collection of rules, Canon Law serves the life and mission of the Church, providing the framework within which rights are protected, responsibilities are fulfilled, and the common good is advanced. As St. Paul reminds us, "All things should be done decently and in order" (1 Cor 14:40).

The Church greatly values the scholarship, dedication, and pastoral sensitivity of canonists, whose expertise helps to harmonise the demands of justice with the imperatives of charity. Through your work, the Church is better equipped to address complex pastoral and juridical questions, resolve disputes fairly, and uphold the dignity of the faithful in accordance with the mind and mission of Christ.

As you convene in Enugu city, may your deliberations be marked by intellectual depth, fidelity to the Church's teaching, and a renewed appreciation of Canon Law as an instrument of communion and pastoral service. May the Holy Spirit enlighten your discussions, strengthen your commitment to ecclesiastical justice, and inspire you to contribute meaningfully to the continued growth and effective governance of the Church in Nigeria

Fraternally yours in Christ,

Callistus V. C Onaga
BISHOP OF ENUGU

CATHOLIC DIOCESE OF ENUGU

CATHOLIC DIOCESE OF UROMI

5th October 2026

Most Rev. Dr. Anthony Okonkwo Gbuji
Bishop Emeritus of Enugu Diocese

My Lord and beloved Patriarch

CONGRATULATIONS ON YOUR 95TH BIRTHDAY

May the peace of God Almighty be with you all your days!
We rejoice with you on the occasion of your 95th birthday. This milestone invites us to look back, recount the wonders of God's grace in your life and be grateful for what He has done in you and through you for the Church in Nigeria.

When the Diocese of Issele-Uku was created on 5th July; 1973, and you were appointed its pioneer Bishop, you were saddled with the responsibility of shepherding the Diocese. Regardless of the inevitable challenges associated with beginning a new Diocese and the effects of the Nigerian Civil War in different parts of the Diocese at the time, you envisioned and built several infrastructures that fostered and continue to enhance the pastoral and spiritual growth of the Diocese. Among these are the establishment of the Emmaus School of Evangelization and the foundation of the Congregation of the New Evangelization Sisters of Our Mother of Perpetual Help.

Your journey lo Enugu in 1997 as Bishop of Enugu Diocese was a response to the call to further the Church's mission of evangelization. To this end, you established St. Paul International Institute of Evangelization in 2001.The institute's relevance led to its upgrade in 2009 to a Faculty of Religious Studies at Godfrey Okoye University, Enugu. Though retired in 2009, you once again responded to the Church's call on 31st May 2010, when you were appointed the Apostolic Administrator of the Archdiocese of Benin City.
As Apostolic Administrator of Benin City Archdiocese, your commitment to the Church's mission of evangelization led to the opening of many autonomous Churches, which have since evolved into parishes. By sending priests to those areas, you offered God's people the joy of having greater access to the celebration of the Holy Mass and the Sacraments, which build and sustain the spiritual lives of the faithful.

My felicitations will be incomplete if I fail to thank you, for ordaining me to the priesthood in Ibusa in 1993. May God be gracious to you all your days as recall my ministry with gratitude.
May your untiring service to God and His Church be a source of fulfilment in your venerable old age. May God be your strength and your peace in this season of your life.
Fraternally Yours in Christ,

Fraternally Yours in Christ,

+A.D.Ogun OSA

Most Rev. Donatus OGUN, OSA
Bishop, Uromi Diocese.

Bigard Memorial Seminary
(Office of the Rector)

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Enugu-Nigeria

BMS/E/D/26/051/JN

His Excellency
Most Rev. Anthony O. Gbuji
Villa Maria Close
EMENE

September 29, 2026

Your Excellency,

95TH BIRTHDAY ANNIVERSARY OF MOST REV. DR. ANTHONY OKONKWO GBUJI

It is with hearts overflowing with profound joy, deep gratitude and spiritual reverence that the Formators, Staff, and Seminarians of Bigard Memorial Seminary, Enugu, felicitate our revered father and a towering colossus of the Church, Most Rev. Dr. Anthony Okonkwo Gbuji, as he reaches the historic milestone of 95 glorious years!

As this year concurrently marks the 38th Canon Law Convention, it is unique to honour a legendary Doctor of Canon Law and founder of the Canon Law Society of Nigeria, who has spent his life interpreting the laws of the Church through the ultimate lens of pastoral love and the salvation of souls.

Your Excellency, your footprint across the landscape of the Catholic Church in Nigeria remains indelible. We recall with deep gratitude and pride the monumental areas of your dedicated service:

As the Pioneer Bishop of Issele-Ukwu Diocese in 1973, you laid a flawless foundation as the first shepherd, building infrastructure, fostering indigenous vocations, and establishing the congregation of the New Evangelization Sisters (NES)

In 1996, you became the Bishop of the Catholic Diocese of Enugu and masterfully steered the Catholic Diocese of Enugu into an era of unprecedented administrative structure, setting the Church on fire for the New Evangelization. Your marvellous works in Enugu Diocese speak for themselves.

Your excellent work, even in retirement, as the Apostolic Administrator of the Archdiocese of Benin from 2010 to 2011 remains a proof of administrative acumen. You remain the oldest living Catholic Bishop in Nigeria, and a symbol of long, faithful service.

On this historic milestone, we pray that the Almighty God, who has kept you as a beacon of faith, continues to renew your strength in good health of mind and body. Ad Multos Annos, Your Excellency!

I remain,

Sincerely yours in Christ.

Very Rev. Fr. Aloysius Ezeoba
Rector

RECTOR BIGARD MEMORIAL SEMINARY ENUGU

Website: www.bigardenugu.org



Daughters of Divine Love Congregation
P O Box 546 Enugu
Enugu State, Nigeria

Phone: 07030804137, 08124848923
E-mail: ddlgen@yahoo.com

18th September, 2026

Very Rev. Fr. Dr. Edwin Omorogbo
President
Canon Law Society of Nigeria

On behalf of the Congregation of the Daughters of Divine Love, I write to congratulate the Canon Law Society of Nigeria on the occasion of its 38th Annual Convention, scheduled for 27-3oth October 2026 at Holy Ghost Cathedral, Enugu

The theme of this year's Convention, "Canon Law and Clerical Political Engagement in Nigeria: Ensuring Ecclesial Unity, Mission, and Credibility", is both timely and significant, it provides a valuable opportunity for refelction and dialogue on the proper application of Canon Law in addressing contemporary challenges within the Church, while promoting ecclesial unity, fidelity to the church's mission and credibility in her witness.

As you gather for this important Convention, may the Holy Spirit guide all your deliberation and grant every participant wisdom and insight. May the Convention strengthen the bonds of fraternity among Canonists nd contribute meaningfully to the growth, unity and vision and mission of the Church in Nigeria.

I also join the society in celebrating the 95th birthday of your reverend Founder, Most Rev. Anthony O. Gbuji. We thank for the gift of his life, his years of dedicated service to the church and his invaluable contributions to the development of Canon Law in Nigeria. May the Lord continue to bless him with good health of mind and body as he gracefully advances in age.

Once again, I congratulate the president, Very Rev. Fr. Dr. Edwin Omorogbo, the leadership and members of the Canon Law Society of Nigeria and all those who have worked tirelessly towards the success of this convention. May this Annual Convention be richly blessed and fruitful, and may God continue to bless the Canon Law Society and her service to the Church.

Yours truly in Christ,

M. Anastasia Dike
Mother General, DDL



New Evangelization Sisters of Our Mother of Perpetual Help
P.O.Box 258 Issele-Uku, Aniocha North L.G.A.
Delta State, Nigeria.

Our Ref:_____ Your Ref:_____ Date: 17/09/2026

HEARTY CONGATULATIONS

Most Rev. Anthony O. Gbuji
Bishop Emeritus, Enugu Diocese
Father Founder, NES

Dear Father Founder,

With hearts filled with joy and profound gratitude to Almighty God, we, your daughters, warmly celebrate and congratulate you on your 95th Birthday.

Ninety-five years of life is indeed remarkable and a great testimony of God's love, mercy, and abundant blessings. We are deeply grateful to God for preserving your life and granting you the grace to witness this memorable occasion.

We are grateful for the gift of your life your faith, your sacrifice, and your dedication to the service of God and His Church.

Through your vision and commitment, you responded generously to God's call and laid the foundation of our Congregation. Your life and spiritual legacy continue to inspire and guide us in living out our vocation and mission.

We celebrate you with gratitude and thanksgiving to God for the precious gift of your life and vocation. May your remaining years be filled with peace, joy, good health, and the satisfaction of seeing the work you began continuing to flourish for the glory of God.

Happy 95th Birthday, our beloved Father Founder



Mother Leonie-Martha O'karaga
Superior General

Email: nessisters@gmail.com
Tel: 08148936390

SOCIETY OF ST PAUL

HEARTY CONGRATULATIONS!

The Congregation of the Society of St Paul (St Paul Book Centre, Holy Ghost Cathedral), warmly congratulates the ***Canon Law Society of Nigeria (CLSN)*** on the successful celebration of its ***38th Annual Convention***. May the Holy Spirit enlighten your deliberations and inspire your mission to uphold the truth, deepen ecclesial communion and strengthen the Church's mission in Nigeria.

We also join the hosts and the universal Catholic community in celebrating the ***95th Birthday of our revered shepherd, Most Rev Anthony Okonkwo Gbuji (Bishop Emeritus of Enugu).*** Your Grace, your exemplary pastoral witness, unwavering commitment to truth, and enduring faith remain a treasured legacy and an inspiration to the Church.

May God continue to bless the Canon Law Society of Nigeria with wisdom and fruitfulness, and may He graciously preserve our beloved Bishop Emeritus in good health, lasting joy and peace.

With prayerful Congratulations and Best Wishes,



Fr. David Berkmans
Society of St. Paul



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Mobile: +234 9028192785. E-mail: superior@stpauls.ng


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CATHOLIC DIOCESE OF ENUGU

St. Bernard Seminary Hostel
Nchatancha-Nike

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Enugu-Nigeria
Phone:08080145528, 09153884530

A CONGRATULATORY MESSAGE TO MOST REV. ANTHONY GBUJI ON HIS 95TH BIRTHDAY

With profound gratitude to Almighty Ged, we the Rector, Management, Staff, and entire community of St. Bernard Seminary Hostel, Nchatancha, Diocese of Enugu joyfully extend our heartfelt felicitations to our beloved father and visionary founder, Most Rev. Anthony O. Gbuji, on the joyous occasion of his 95th birthday. Your Lordship, your life has been a remarkable testament to faith, wisdom, and selfless service to God and His Church. Through your vision in founding this Hostel, you planted a seed that continues to nurture vocations and shape the Church's future. Your legacy endures in every life touched and every vocation nurtured within these walls.

As you celebrate this distinguished milestone, we pray that the Good Shepherd will renew your strength, preserve your health, and fill your days with peace and joy. May Our Blessed Mother and St. Bernard, our heavenly patron, continue to intercede for you. Happy 95th Birthday, Your Lordship. May the years ahead be filled with God's abundant blessings, and may you continue to flourish in His vineyard. Ad multos annos, your Lordship

SIGNED:

The Rector and the entire family of
Bernard Seminary Hostel, Nchatancha.

ENUGU DIOCESAN CATHOLIC YOUNG WOMEN ORGANIZATION (EDCYWO)

Our Ref: ..... *Your Ref:* ..... *Date:* .....

The members of Catholic Young Women Organization, Enugu Diocese, joyfully congratulate the Canon Law Society of Nigeria on its 38th Annual Convention and felicitate with Most Rev. Anthony Okonkwo Gbuji on the momentous occasion of his 95th birthday. Your Lordship, your life is a testament to the enduring power of faith, dedication, and service. As the founding father of the CLSN, you have contributed significantly to the advancement of canon law and the strengthening of the Church's institutional life in Nigeria. Your legacy continues to inspire young Catholics to embrace their vocations and serve God with commitment and integrity.

We sincerely appreciate our Bishop, Most Rev. Callistus V. C. Onaga, for bringing this prestigious gathering to Enugu Diocese, and Most Rev. Ernest Obodo, Chairman of the Local Organizing Committee, for his commitment to ensuring a successful convention.

We pray that God will continue to bless Bishop Gbuji with sound health and peace of mind and inspire the younger generation through his remarkable example.

Happy 95th birthday, Your Lordship! Your legacy lives on in the hearts of generations yet to come.



MOTHER OF PERPETUAL HELP GIRLS' JUNIORATE
ISSELE -UKU
DELTA STATE
CARITAS ET SERVITIUM

A Collective Tribute to OUR FATHER FOUNDER @95

HAPPY 95TH BIRTHDAY TO EMERITUS BISHOP ANTHONY OKONKWO GBUJI!

With one heart and one voice, we, the Old Girls of Mother of Perpetual Help Girls' Juniorate, Issele-Uku, celebrate our beloved Father Founder, whose vision shaped our lives, whose values built our character, and whose legacy continues to inspire generations.

We honour your sacrifices and thank God for your remarkable life. May He grant you sound health, peace, joy, and many more blessed years.

Together, we celebrate you; together, we honour your legacy; forever, we remain your grateful daughters.

Happy 95th Birthday, Our Father Founder!

With love, gratitude, and prayers.

The Old Girls of Mother of Perpetual Help Girls' Juniorate, Issele-Uku.

Caritas et Servitium — Love and Service.





ST. ANTHONY OF PADUA
851 Main Street

WOBURN CATHOLIC COLLABORATIVE

BUSINESS OFFICE
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Woburn, MA 01801

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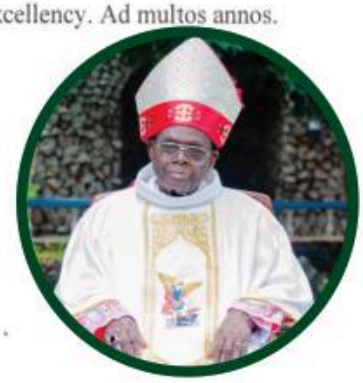
ST. BARBARA
138 Cambridge Road

HAPPY 95TH BIRTHDAY, BISHOP ANTHONY OKONKWO GBUJI.

On behalf of the Woburn Catholic Collaborative of Sts. Anthony and Barbara parishes, we joyfully congratulate you, Bishop Anthony Okonkwo Gbuji, Emeritus Catholic Bishop of Enugu diocese, Nigeria, on the grace-filled celebration of your 95th birthday.

We thank Almighty God for the gift of your life, your faithful service to the Church, and your enduring pastoral love. Like fine wine, Your Excellency, you grow more precious with age. As you celebrate this remarkable milestone, may the Lord renew your strength, fill your heart with peace, and surround you with blessings in a most abundant way. May Mary, our Blessed Mother, intercede for you always. Amen.

Happy 95TH Birthday, Your Excellency. Ad multos annos.



Rev. Dr. Edmund Ugwoegbu

Rev. Paschal Ekediegwu.

Woburn Catholic Collaborative, Archdiocese of Boston, United States of America.



NEW EVANGELIZATION RESEARCH AND MINISTRY (NERAM)

Certificate Programme of Godfrey Okoye University.

ENUGU, NIGERIA

Our Ref:---------- ***Your Ref:***---------- ***Date:***----------
5 October 2026

BIRTHDAY FELICITATION TO HIS EXCELLENCY, MOST REV DR. ANTHONY GBUJI, BISHOP EMERITUS OF THE CATHOLIC DIOCESE OF ENUGU, ON HIS 95TH BIRTHAY

Your Excellency,
Most Rev. Dr. Anthony O. Gbuji
Bishop Emeritus of the Catholic Diocese of Enugu

On behalf of the Management, Staff, Student and entire New Evangelization Research and Ministry - NERAM, School of Evangelization, Enugu, we joyffully celebrate and wamly congratulate you on the remarkable occasion of your 95th birthday.

Today, we give thanks to God Almighty for your life and for the many years you have devoted to the service of God, Church an humanity. Your 95th year is a show of God's faithfulness, grace and abundant blessings.

Your Excellency, we especially celebrate you as the founder of the school of Evangelization in Nigeria and the founding father of NERAM school of Evengelization, Enugu. Your vision and commitment to evangelization have contributed greatly to the formation of evangelizers and the spread of the Gospel. The legacy you have established continues to inspire and empower generations of people to become committed witnesses of Christ.

As members of the NERAM family, we are deeply grateful for the Foundation you laid and for the opportunity to continue building on your vision. We assure you of our commitment to preserving and promoting the spirit of evangelization, Christian formation and service which you so passionately cherished.

On this special occasion, we pray that Almighty God will continue to strengthen you, bless you with good health, peace, joy and renewed grace, May He reward you abundantly for your years of dedicated service to His Church and grant you many more fruitful years.
Your Excellency, we celebrate your life, we honour your legacy and we thank God for the gift of your presence among us.

Happy 95th Birthday, Your Excellency!
Congratulations, our Father and Founder!
Ad Multos Annos!

NEW EVANGELISATION RESEARCH AND MINISTRY (NERAM) ENUGU
Sign.....
Date 5/10/26

Rev. Fr; Dr. Callistus Anieke
Director of NERA, School of Evangelization, Enugu

THE INTER-DIOCESAN TRIBUNAL - ENUGU

Email: *tribunalenugudiocese@yahoo.com*

CATHOLIC DIOCESAN SECRETARIAT,
HOLY GHOST CATHEDRAL, OGUI
P.O.BOX 302 - ENUGU,
PHONE: 07073861985

15th October, 2026

GOODWILL MESSAGE

The President and the entire staff of the inter-Diocesan Tribunal Enugu, heartily convey our goodwill message to the Canon Law Society of Nigeria on her 38th annual Convention here in Enugu.

We also felicitate with the Emeritus Bishop of Enugu Diocese, Most Rev. Anthony Okonkwo Gbuji, on his 95th birthday celebration.

My Lord, your valuable and significant inputs into the tribunal system in the diocese can never be over emphasized. In fact, the Inter-Diocesan Tribunal as we know it today is your brainchild. You did not just revive it; you promoted it to the enviable standard it enjoys today.

Upon becoming the moderator of the Tribunal, you took the bull by the horn and cleared about 600 backlogs of marriage cases that piled up in the past years. Indeed, the canonical expertise with which you reconstituted and restructured the Tribunal enabled it through the years to become a place of divine healing far the brokenhearted

We are very grateful for you, and thank God for the gift of you to our diocese and to the universal church.

Ad multos annos my Lord

Rev. Fr. Michael CHIME
PRESIDENT

Rev. Fr. Paul UCHE
ECC., NOTARY

INTER-DIOCESAN TRIBUNAL ENUGU

MOTTO: *SALUS ANIMARUM*

CATHOLIC DIOCESE OF ENUGU

UDI DEANERY

A Celebration of Wisdom, Faith and Distinguished Service

We heartily felicitate with the Canon Law Society of Nigeria on the occasion of its 38th Annual Convention hosted by the Catholic Diocese of Enugu.

We particularly rejoice with our beloved Emeritus Bishop of Enugu, Most Rev. Anthony Okonkwo Gbuji, the founding father of the CLSN, as he celebrates his remarkable 95th birthday. His life of faith, wisdom, pastoral dedication, and service to the Church remains an enduring inspiration to generations of priests, religious, and lay faithful.

We express our profound appreciation to our indefatigable Bishop, Most Rev. Callistus V. C. Onaga, for graciously hosting this important ecclesiastical gathering in Enugu Diocese. We also commend Most Rev. Ernest Obodo, Auxiliary Bishop of Enugu and Apostolic Administrator of Abakaliki Diocese, for his dedicated leadership as Chairman of the Local Organizing Committee.

May this convention strengthen the Church's commitment to justice, sound canonical practice, and the faithful administration of ecclesiastical affairs. May God continue to bless Bishop Gbuji with peace, good health, and abundant grace.

Congratulations

& Happy 95th birthday, our Revered Father!

Very Rev. Fr. Benjamin Ochiagha
Dean, Udi Deanery



CATHOLIC DIOCESE OF ENUGU

EMENE DEANERY



A Historic Convention and a Celebration of an Extraordinary Life

We heartily congratulate the Canon Law Society of Nigeria on the successful hosting of its 38th Annual Convention in the Catholic Diocese of Enugu.

We consider it a special privilege that this important gathering coincides with the 95th birthday celebration of Most Rev. Anthony Okonkwo Gbuji, Emeritus Bishop of Enugu and founding father of the CLSN. We give thanks to God for his remarkable life, distinguished episcopal ministry, and enduring contribution to the growth and development of the Catholic Church in Nigeria.

We express our profound gratitude to Most Rev. Callistus V. C. Onaga, Bishop of Enugu, for the honour of hosting this august assembly of canon lawyers and other distinguished members of the Church. His hospitality reflects the Diocese's commitment to fostering ecclesiastical scholarship, collaboration, and pastoral development.

We also commend Most Rev. Ernest Obodo, Auxiliary Bishop of Enugu and Apostolic Administrator of Abakaliki Diocese, whose service as Chairman of the Local Organizing Committee has been instrumental in coordinating this significant gathering.
As we celebrate Bishop Gbuji's 95 years of life and the continued growth of the CLSN, we pray that Almighty God will grant the Society renewed wisdom in its service to the Church and bless our revered Emeritus Bishop with peace, strength, and abundant grace.

Congratulations
to the Canon Law Society of Nigeria.

Happy 95th birthday,
Most Rev. Anthony Okonkwo Gbuji!

May the Lord continue to bless you and make your legacy fruitful for generations to come

Very Rev. Fr. Malachy Ezeonu
Dean, Emene Deanery



CATHOLIC DIOCESE OF ENUGU

ST JOSEPH PARISH, EMENE

Your Ref: ..... *Date:* .....

Our Ref: .....

GOODWILL Message



A Golden Opportunity to Celebrate a Shepherd's Legacy

The Parish Pastoral Council and the entire faithful of St. Joseph Parish Emene warmly congratulate the Canon Law Society of Nigeria on its 38th Annual Convention and celebrate the 95th birthday of Most Rev. Anthony Okonkwo Gbuji, Emeritus Bishop of Enugu and founding father of the Society.

This remarkable celebration offers us an opportunity to give thanks to God for a shepherd whose life has been devoted to the service of the Gospel and the advancement of the Church. Bishop Gbuji's legacy remains a treasured gift to the Diocese of Enugu and the wider Nigerian Catholic community.
We are grateful to Most Rev. Callistus V. C. Onaga, our diocesan shepherd, for hosting this distinguished convention, which brings together experts and practitioners in canon law for reflection, collaboration, and the strengthening of ecclesiastical life.

We also salute Most Rev. Ernest Obodo, Auxiliary Bishop of Enugu and Apostolic Administrator of Abakaliki Diocese, for accepting the responsibility of leading the Local Organizing Committee.
May God bless this convention with fruitful deliberations and grant our beloved Bishop Gbuji continued strength, peace, and happiness.

Ad multos annos, Your Lordship! May you continue to flourish in the grace of God.

Very Rev. Fr. Malachy Ezeonu
Parish Priest



CATHOLIC DIOCESE OF ENUGU

ST MARY PARISH, IHUOKPARA

Your Ref: ..... *Date:* .....

Our Ref: .....



Felicitations

The faithful of St Mary Parish, Ihuokpara, rejoice with the Canon Law Society of Nigeria on the joyful occasion of its 38th Annual Convention. We give thanks to God for the long and fruitful life of Most Rev. Anthony Okonkwo Gbuji, whose 95th birthday we gratefully commemorate, and whose foundational role in the CLSN continues to inspire.

We acknowledge with deep gratitude the hospitality of Most Rev. C.V.C. Onaga, Bishop of Enugu, and the dedicated service of Most Rev. Ernest Obodo, Auxiliary Bishop and Apostolic Administrator of Abakaliki, who chairs the Local Organizing Committee. May the Holy Spirit guide all deliberations and renew the Society's commitment to justice and truth in the Church.



CATHOLIC DIOCESE OF ENUGU

ENUGU DIOCESAN CATHOLIC YOUNG MEN ORGANIZATION (EDCYMO)

Message of Goodwill

The members of Enugu Diocesan Catholic Young Men Organization, joins the Canon Law Society of Nigeria in thanksgiving for its 38th Annual Convention, taking place in the Diocese of Enugu. We honour Most Rev. Anthony Okonkwo Gbuji on the happy occasion of his 95th birthday and recall with gratitude his pioneering contribution as Founding Father of the CLSN.

We express our sincere appreciation to Most Rev. C.V.C. Onaga, Bishop of Enugu, for his generous hospitality, and to Most Rev. Ernest Obodo, Auxiliary Bishop of Enugu and Apostolic Administrator of Abakaliki Diocese, for coordinating the Local Organizing Committee with such care. May this Convention strengthen the bonds of communion and service within the Church in Nigeria.

CATHOLIC DIOCESE OF ENUGU

ENUGU DIOCESAN CATHOLIC MEN ORGANIZATION (EDCMO)

Our Ref: ..... *Your Ref:* ..... *Date:* .....

GOODWILL MESSAGE

Honouring a Legacy of Faith and Service

With hearts filled with joy and gratitude to God, the members of Enugu Diocesan Catholic Men Organization (EDCMO), congratulate the Canon Law Society of Nigeria on its 38th Annual Convention and celebrate the 95th birthday of Most Rev. Anthony Okonkwo Gbuji, the Society's founding father.

At 95, Bishop Gbuji stands as a remarkable witness to God's faithfulness and a shining example of a life devoted to the service of the Church. His enduring legacy of pastoral leadership, wisdom, and commitment to the growth of the Church deserves our profound gratitude and admiration.

We warmly appreciate Most Rev. Callistus V. C. Onaga, Bishop of Enugu, for the honour of hosting this distinguished convention in our beloved diocese. We equally acknowledge Most Rev. Ernest Obodo for his invaluable contributions and commitment as Chairman of the Local Organizing Committee.

As we celebrate this historic occasion, we pray that Almighty God will continue to uphold our beloved Bishop Gbuji and bless all participants at the convention.
May the Lord reward your years of faithful service with renewed strength, peace, and joy.
Congratulations!





CATHOLIC DIOCESE OF ENUGU

ENUGU DIOCESAN CATHOLIC WOMEN ORGANIZATION (EDCWO)

Our Ref: ..... *Your Ref:* ..... *Date:* .....

GOODWILL MESSAGE

A Life of Grace, Wisdom and Fatherly Love

The members of Enugu Diocesan Catholic Women's Organization heartily felicitate with the Canon Law Society of Nigeria on its 38th Annual Convention and join the universal Church in celebrating the 95th birthday of our beloved Emeritus Bishop, Most Rev. Anthony Okonkwo Gbuji.

Your Lordship, we thank God for your fruitful years of priestly and episcopal ministry, your fatherly presence, and your invaluable contributions to the growth of the Catholic Church. Your life of faith and dedication remains a source of encouragement to families, women, and the entire Christian community.

We commend Most Rev. Callistus V. C. Onaga, Bishop of Enugu, for the warm hospitality extended to the CLSN through the hosting of this convention. We also express our sincere appreciation to Most Rev. Ernest Obodo, Auxiliary Bishop of Enugu and Apostolic Administrator of Abakaliki Diocese, for his leadership as Chairman of the Local Organizing Committee.

As we celebrate this exceptional milestone, we pray that the Blessed Virgin Mary will continue to intercede for Bishop Gbuji, obtaining for him good health, peace, and the joy of the Lord.

Congratulations, Your Lordship, on your 95th birthday! May your remaining years be filled with God's abundant blessings.



CATHOLIC DIOCESE OF ENUGU

ENUGU DEANERY

Felicitations

With joyful hearts, Enugu Deanery extends cordial greetings to the Canon Law Society of Nigeria on the occasion of its 38th Annual Convention.

We unite our prayers with the Society in celebrating the 95th birthday of Most Rev. Anthony Okonkwo Gbuji, Emeritus Bishop and Founding Father of the CLSN.

Special thanks are due to Most Rev. C.V.C. Onaga for welcoming the Convention to Enugu Diocese, and to Most Rev. Ernest Obodo for his dedicated chairmanship of the Local Organizing Committee.

May Almighty God bless all participants and grant them wisdom and grace in their service to the Church.

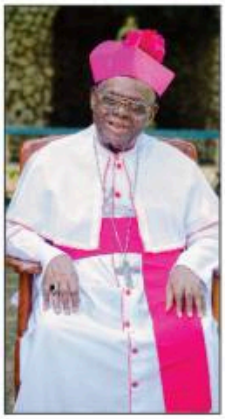
Very Rev. Fr. Benjamin Eze
Dean, Engu Deanery



CATHOLIC DIOCESE OF ENUGU

AGBANI DEANERY





Felicitation

The Catholic faithful of Agbani Deanery warmly congratulate the Canon Law Society of Nigeria on its 38th Annual Convention and celebrate the 95th birthday of Most Rev. Anthony Okonkwo Gbuji, Emeritus Bishop of Enugu and founding father of the Society.

This remarkable celebration offers us an opportunity to give thanks to God for a shepherd whose life has been devoted to the service of the Gospel and the advancement of the Church. Bishop Gbuji's legacy remains a treasured gift to the Diocese of Enugu and the wider Nigerian Catholic community.

We are grateful to Most Rev. Callistus V. C. Onaga, our diocesan shepherd, for hosting this distinguished convention, which brings together experts and practitioners in canon law for reflection, collaboration, and the strengthening of ecclesiastical life.

We also salute Most Rev. Ernest Obodo, Auxiliary Bishop of Enugu and Apostolic Administrator of Abakaliki Diocese, for accepting the responsibility of leading the Local Organizing Committee.

May God bless this convention with fruitful deliberations and grant our beloved Bishop Gbuji continued strength, peace, and happiness.
Ad multos annos, Your Lordship! May you continue to flourish in the grace of God.

Very Rev. Fr. Augustine Otugo
Dean, Agbani Deanery

CATHOLIC DIOCESE OF ENUGU

NKWO-NIKE DEANERY

Goodwill Message



With fraternal affection and prayerful support, the faithful of Nkwo Nike Deanery congratulate the Canon Law Society of Nigeria on the successful holding of its 38th Annual Convention in Enugu Diocese.

We give thanks for the long life of Most Rev. Anthony Okonkwo Gbuji, who marks his 95th birthday, and whose vision as Founding Father continues to guide the Society. Special recognition is due to Most Rev. C.V.C. Onaga for hosting the Convention, and to Most Rev. Ernest Obodo for his dedicated service as Chairman of the Local Organizing Committee.

May this celebration deepen the Society's fidelity to the Church and bear lasting fruit for the people of God.



Very Rev. Fr. Stanislaus Zeowa
Dean, Nkwo-Nike Deanery

CATHOLIC DIOCESE OF ENUGU

EMMANUEL PARISH, EMENE



GOODWILL MESSAGE ON THE 95TH BIRTHDAY OF MOST REV. DR. ANTHONY OKONKWO GBUJI

Emmanuel Catholic Parish, Emene, heartily congratulates Most Rev. Dr. Anthony Okonkwo Gbuji on the joyous celebration of his 95th birthday, 68 years of priestly ministry, and 53 years of episcopal service. Your life of faith, sacrifice, and dedicated service to God and His Church remains a shining testimony of God's abundant grace and faithfulness. We thank the Almighty God for your fruitful ministry and enduring legacy.

As you celebrate this remarkable milestone, we pray that the Lord will continue to strengthen you, bless you with peace and good health, and fill your heart with lasting joy. Happy 95th Birthday, Your Lordship! May the good Lord crown your years with His unfailing love and grant you strength and peace in His presence.

Fr. Charles Onwuama, OP.
Parish Priest.

Dr. Uche Ani
1st Vice Chairman, Parish Pastoral Council



ST. MARK PARISH ABIA

HeartFelt Felicitation

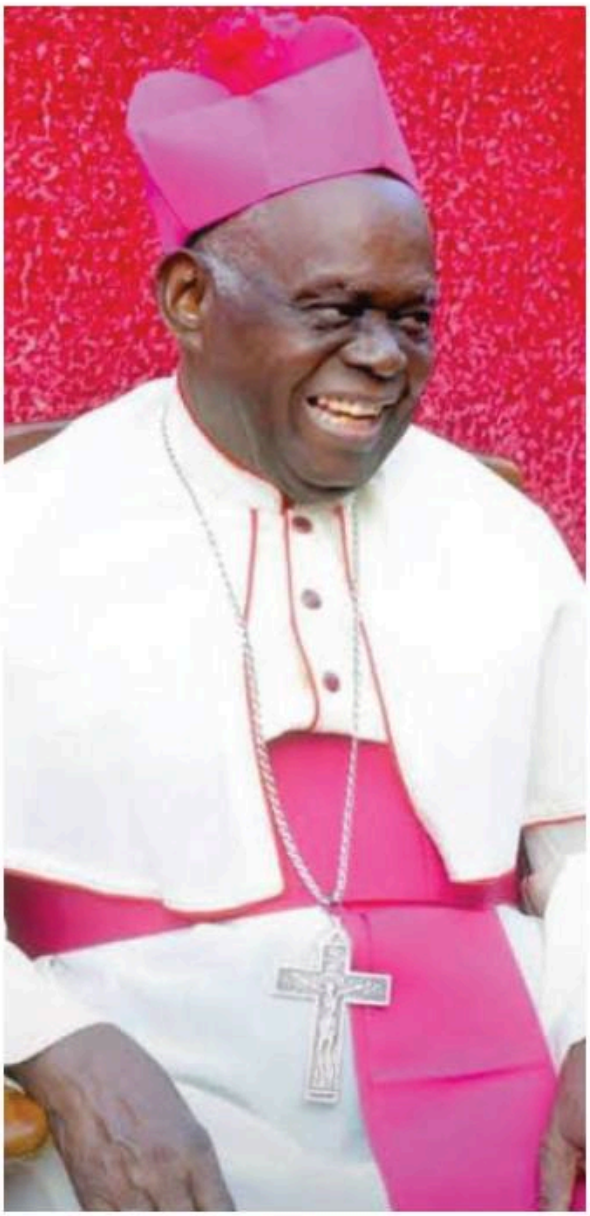
The Parish Priest and the entire faithful of St. Mark Parish Abia, rejoice with the Canon Law Society of Nigeria on the joyful occasion of its 38th Annual Convention. We give thanks to God for the long and fruitful life of Most Rev. Anthony Okonkwo Gbuji, whose 95th birthday we gratefully commemorate, and whose foundational role in the CLSN continues to inspire.

We acknowledge with deep gratitude the hospitality of Most Rev. C.V.C. Onaga, Bishop of Enugu, and the dedicated service of Most Rev. Ernest Obodo, Auxiliary Bishop and Apostolic Administrator of Abakaliki, who chairs the Local Organizing Committee. May the Holy Spirit guide all deliberations and renew the Societys commitment to justice and truth in the Church.

Very Rev. Fr. Ifunanya Aneke
Parish Priest

CATHOLIC DIOCESE OF ENUGU

AGUOBU OWA DEANERY



Goodwill Message

On this auspicious occasion of the 38th Annual Convention of the Canon Law Society of Nigeria, the Faithfu of Aguobu Owa Deanery send warmest goodwill and congratulations. We rejoice especially at the 95th birthday of Most Rev. Anthony Okonkwo Gbuji, Emeritus Bishop and Founding Father of the CLSN.

Our heartfelt thanks go to Most Rev. C.V.C. Onaga for the gracious hospitality of the Diocese of Enugu, and to Most Rev. Ernest Obodo for his leadership as Chairman of the Local Organizing Committee. May the Lord continue to sustain Bishop Gbuji and prosper the work of the Society.

Very Rev. Fr. Dennis Eze
Dean, Aguobu-Owa Deanery

EZEOYIBO FAMILY COMPOUND

Chief Hon Dr. (Sir) Hamaka C. Nwoye, KSJI, J.P., Ph. D COH
(Papal Medalist & Chinechendo N'Affa)

4th October, 2026

FELICITATION TO THE DOYEN OF EVANGELISM, AND THE "CARDINAL" WE NEVER HAD, EMERITUS BISHOP OF ENUGU DIOCESE, MOST REV. DR. ANTHONY OKONKWO GBUJI ON HIS 95TH BIRTHDAY, AND 53 YEARS OF EPISCOPAL ORDINATION.

With distinct honor and special privilege, the family of Chief Hon. Dr. (Sir) and Lolo Hamaka C. Nwoye Ezeoyibo felicitates with our dear Father in Faith, His Lordship, Emeritus Bishop of Enugu Diocese, Most Rev. Dr. Anthony Okonkwo Gbuji, on his rare and unprecedented dual celebrations of 95 years of birth and 53 years of Episcopacy.

As a clergy, Bishop and Canonist, possessed of vast spiritual insight and power, his consuming love for Christ and humanity did burst forth in all his pronouncements and actions. Bishop Gbuji is a multi-faceted pastoral genius, endowed with high character, cultivated intellect, and great physical courage; a Pastor of deep prayer and piety, with unrestricted love for the word of God, who preaches the Gospel by words and prolific writings. He is a consummate administrator and compass of frugality, as manifested in his establishment of St. Bernard Hostel, Seminary Nchatancha Emene Enugu, the Holy Ghost Cathedral Arena etc. He carried out his Episcopal duties in Enugu Diocese as at his all other Episcopal postings punctiliously, with vigor and passion, leaving behind monumental legacies for other Bishops and clergy coming after him. Our prayer for him is many more years of buoyant health, clarity of mind, jollity and heavenly blessings.
Ad multos Annos!



FROM SUDDEN AND UNPROVIDED DEATH, LORD JESUS, DELIVER ME":

A Theological Reflection on the Death of Archbishop Augustine Obiora Akubeze

By Rev. Fr. Edwin Omorogbe (a priest of Benin city and President of Canon Law Society of Nigeria)

20 July 2027



1. Among the enduring petitions of Catholic devotion is the prayer: *"From sudden and unprovided death, Lord Jesus, deliver me."* Traditionally, it has expressed the Christian desire to receive the sacraments before death. Yet its deeper meaning concerns not the timing of death but the spiritual condition in which death finds the believer.

2. The sudden passing of Archbishop Augustine Obiora Akubeze invites renewed reflection on this prayer. His life was marked by faithful service as Bishop of Uromi, Archbishop of Benin City, Vice President and President of the Catholic Bishops' Conference of Nigeria, distinguished canonist, and courageous pastor. He combined theological depth, prudent leadership, intellectual humility, and pastoral charity, while consistently promoting consultation, justice, ecclesial communion, and fidelity to the Gospel.

3. One of his final scholarly contributions reflected on the Eucharist as the source of authentic evangelization. He insisted that effective ministry flows from reverent celebration of the Sacred Liturgy and faithful Eucharistic adoration. Providentially, one of his last journeys was to the Monastery of the Holy Spirit in Conyers, Georgia, where he went to pray and obtain religious articles for the faithful entrusted to his care. Even in his final days, his heart remained directed toward God and the spiritual welfare of others.

4. His sudden death should not be interpreted as evidence that God failed to answer the Church's prayer. Rather, it invites a deeper understanding of its meaning. The Church teaches that God has bound salvation to the sacraments, yet He Himself is not bound by them (CCC 1257). Consequently, not every sudden death is an unprovided death. The decisive question is not whether death comes unexpectedly, but whether it finds a person living in the grace and friendship of God.

5. Christ repeatedly called His disciples to constant vigilance: "Be ready, for the Son of Man is coming at an hour you do not expect" (Mt. 24:44). The saints remind us that holiness is measured less by the manner of one's death than by the manner of one's life. Archbishop Akubeze's decades of faithful priestly and episcopal ministry inspire us to commend him confidently to God's infinite mercy while praying for the repose of his soul.

6. The lesson of his passing is clear. Human plans remain uncertain, but divine providence never fails. As James Anthony Froude observed, "Events mock at human foresight." Christian faith adds that they never mock God's providence. Therefore, the prayer remains ever relevant: not simply that we may avoid an unexpected death, but that whenever death comes, it may find us reconciled with God, living faithfully in His grace, and ready to enter the joy of our Lord.



ADORATION MINISTRY ENUGU NIGERIA (AMEN)

Felicitations

A Tribute Of Gratitude, Love and Filial Affection to
MOST REV. ANTHONY OKONKWO GBUJI
On his 95th Birthday

With a heart overflowing with gratitude to God, profound respect and filial affection, I, Rev. Fr. Ejike Mbaka, and all members of Adoration Ministry, joyfully felicitate with my revered father in the Lord, Most Rev. Anthony Okonkwo Gbuji, on the glorious occasion of his 95th birthday.
Your Lordship, attaining 95 years is a remarkable testimony to God's faithfulness, a life enriched by divine grace, and a priestly journey marked by sacrifice, wisdom, generosity and unwavering commitment to the mission of Christ.

As you celebrate this extraordinary milestone, my heart returns with deep appreciation to the years when you served as the Catholic Bishop of Enugu. I remain profoundly grateful for your fatherly support, encouragement and benevolence towards me and the Adoration Ministry. Your faith in my spiritual gifts and in Adoration Ministry God had entrusted to me and your willingness to support its growth remain treasured chapters in my priestly journey. My beloved Papa Gbuji, I honor you for our unique, quintessential, iconic and legendary love for the Adoration ministry Enugu Nigeria (AMEN).

You were not merely a shepherd of the Diocese; you were also a father who recognised, encouraged and nurtured the gifts of God in His people. Your support strengthened my hands in ministry and encouraged me to continue responding courageously to the divine mandate of evangelisation through prayer, worship and the proclamation of God's Word.

As you celebrate 95 years of life, I pray that the Almighty God, who has sustained you through the years, will continue to renew your strength, preserve your health, deepen your joy and surround you with His abiding presence. May Our Blessed Mother Mary continue to intercede for you, and may the Holy Spirit fill your remaining years with peace, grace and abundant blessings.

Happy 95th Birthday, Your Lordship!

Rev. Fr. Ejike C. Mbaka



APPRECIATION

Give thanks to the Lord, for He is good; for His love endures forever!- Psalm 107:1.



On behalf of His Excellency, **Most Rev. Ernest Obodo**, Chairman of the Canon Law Commission of the Catholic Bishops' Conference of Nigeria (CBCN), and the Local Organising Committee (LOC), we thank all whose efforts made this celebration a huge success.

We extend special thanks to the **Canon Law Society of Nigeria (CLSN)**, especially the President, **Very Rev. Fr Edwin Omorogbe**, and his Executive, for choosing the Catholic Diocese of Enugu to host the **38th Annual Convention.** This year's gathering is special as we honour the founder of the Canon Law Society of Nigeria, **Most Rev. Anthony Okonkwo Gbuji**, on his 95th birthday.

We thank His Excellency, **Most Rev. Callistus Onaga**, the Catholic Bishop of Enugu, for hosting the Convention and ensuring Bishop Gbuji's birthday was celebrated with honour. We appreciate His Excellency, the Executive Governor of Enugu State, **Dr Peter Ndubuisi Mbah,** for his steadfast support. We deeply appreciate **Most Rev. Ernest Obodo**, the Auxiliary Bishop of Enugu and Apostolic Administrator of Abakaliki Diocese, and all the members of the LOC for their wonderful collaboration. We also thank the priests, religious, and lay faithful of Enugu Diocese for their teamwork, hospitality, and prayers, which made the Convention and birthday celebrations memorable.

Congratulations to the **award recipients** for their outstanding professional contributions, dedication to law and human dignity in Nigeria, and vital support of the Canon Law Society.
To all our guests, thank you for coming and sharing in this celebration. May God grant you a safe journey and bless Nigeria with peace, justice, unity, security and good governance.

Finally, we prayerfully remember **Most Rev. Augustine Akubueze**, a devoted member and pillar of the Canon Law Society of Nigeria. May Christ welcome him into eternal rest, and may his memory be a lasting blessing. **God bless you all!**

Very Rev. Fr Dr Alfred Emeka Nwoye
Judicial Vicar, Catholic Diocese of Enugu
Vice Chairman, LOC

Catholic Institute for Development, Justice and Peace

Rc7461

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CIDJAP SALUTES

Our Teacher. Our Shepherd. Diokpa Anyi:

The Most Reverend Doctor Anthony Okonkwo Gbuji, Bishop Emeritus of Enugu, at ninety-five

Born 1931 - Priest 1058 Bishop of Issele-Uku 1973 Bishop of Enugu 1997. Ninety-five on 29 October 2026

In 1973, the new Diocese of Issele-Uku, across the Niger in what is now Delta State, had a bishop but no bishop's house. Its first bishop moved into a classroom and lived there for eight months while the house was finished. The civil war had ended three years before. Priests were few, Catholics fewer. He was not deterred. Classrooms were familiar ground.

Before he was the Most Reverend Doctor Anthony Gbuji, Okonkwo was the son of a catechist from Akwukwu-Igbo, near Asaba. He was ordained in Rome in 1958, took a doctorate in canon law, the Church's own body of law, and then a diploma in education in London. He served at St Paul's Minor Seminary in Benin City. When war came in 1967, he organised help for refugees, and later moved the teachers' college he headed at Ibusa out of the line of fire to Issele-Uku.
In twenty-three years, he gave Issele-Uku what a diocese needs to outlive its pioneer shepherd. He gathered Catholics into small Christian communities in the villages. He trained catechists, lay teachers of the faith, to serve where no priest lived. He opened a minor seminary, a secondary school for boys drawn to the priesthood, in 1983; the Emmaus School of Evangelisation in 1989; and in 1993 a new congregation of women religious, the New Evangelisation Sisters.

In 1997 he came to Enugu as our bishop. He founded St Paul's International Institute of Evangelisation and the St Bernard Seminary Hostel at Nchatancha, and in 2005 saw Awgu, long part of the diocese, become a diocese of its own. The idea of a Catholic university for Enugu was first his. Godfrey Okoye University opened in 2009, the year he retired, and its teaching hospital at Trans-Ekulu began as CIDJAP's Ntasi Obi Ndinonafufu Specialist Hospital. The bishop who began in a humble classroom had cultivated a university as a final gift to his flock. His vision and challenge is for Godfrey Okoye University to become an enduring intellectual oasis in the heart of Enugu.

Some of this CIDJAP saw from within. From 1997 to 2004 our Founder, Professor Doctor Monsignor Obiora Ike, served as his Vicar General, the bishop's chief aide in governing the diocese. For twelve years, CIDJAP's work among the poor of Enugu went on under Bishop Gbuji's care. He embodied the principle CIDJAP has upheld for four decades: enduring institutions are the surest tools of grassroots emancipation and integral human development.

In 2023, past ninety, his kinsmen at Umuekeke, Akwukwu-Igbo, made him their Diokpa, the eldest of the lineage. He is Diokpa ndi Akwukwu-Igbo. To the Diocese of Enugu and to CIDJAP, he is our Diokpa too! The fruit of his labour in the Lord's vineyard stand in Issele-Uku and in Enugu for anyone to see.
CIDJAP thanks God for the privilege of celebrating one of Christ's great overseers as he continues his mission, *Ad Jesum per Mariam*: to Jesus through Mary

SIGNED:

Prof. Dr. Msgr. Obiora Ike
Founder and Director, CIDJAP

Rev. Fr. Chidiebere Paul Ani
Deputy Director, CIDJAP

Chief Goddy Ike
Director of Administration, CIDJAP

CATHOLIC DIOCESE OF ENUGU

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